UNIVERSITY OF CAMBRIDGE

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Racialisation, Legal Categorisation and Public Attitudes to Refugees in Germany, 2014-2024

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List of Abbreviations

Abbreviation	Meaning (German)	Meaning (English)
AfD	Alternative für Deutschland	Alternative for Germany; a right-wing extremist, populist political party in Germany
BRD	Bundesrepublik Deutschland	Federal Republic of Germany; refers both to the former West German and modern German states
BKA	Bundeskriminalamt	Federal Criminal Police Office
CDU	Christlich Demokratische Union	Christian Democratic Union; a centre-right mainstream political party in Germany
CSU	Christlich-Soziale Union	Christian Social Union; a centre-right Bavarian political party partnered with the CDU at the federal level
ESS	———	European Social Survey; a cross-national survey conducted across Europe since 2001
EU	Europäische Union	European Union
MENA	———	Middle East and North Africa
PEGIDA	Patriotische Europäer gegen die Islamisierung des Abendlandes	Patriotic Europeans Against the Islamisation of the Occident; an extremist, anti-migrant political group with strong domestic ties to the AfD
SOEP	Sozio-ökonomische Panel	Socio-Economic Panel; a multidisciplinary survey conducted by the German Institute for Economic Research
SPD	Sozialdemokratische Partei Deutschlands	Social Democratic Party of Germany; a centre-left mainstream political party in Germany
SVR	Sachverständnisrat für Integration und Migration	Expert Council for Integration and Migration; a Berlin-based research council dedicated to integration and migration
TAZ	*Die Tageszeitung*	Literally, "*The Daily Newspaper*"; a hard-left newspaper based in Berlin with a relatively small circulation

Abstract

Over the past decade, Germany has become embroiled in several concurrent refugee crises. Under the leadership of successive, mainstream governments, Germany took on a large share of responsibility for refugee arrivals to the European Union (EU), with Germany's government eventually succumbing to confused messaging on migration and mixed legislative approaches toward arriving refugees. This dissertation explores 21st-century German belonging through the matrix of German public opinion, quantitative indicators and policy responses during two refugee crises – the 2015 Syrian crisis and the 2022 Ukrainian crisis. The project examines the dimensions of belonging in Germany, including racial, religious, economic and gender-based prejudices, to understand constructs of inclusion in Germany more broadly. The project adopts a mixed-methods, interpretivist approach, drawing on interviews with expert voices across the academic, political and civil spheres of society, quantitative data analyses challenging dominant anti-migrant narratives and discourse analyses across mainstream and alternative media spaces. Taken together, these methodological choices allow me to trace how policy, discourse and aesthetics operate in tandem to shape refugee reception in Germany's political and cultural imagination.

1. Introduction

Over the past decade, Germany has responded to two major refugee waves – the arrival of Syrians fleeing the Syrian Civil War between 2014 and 2016, and the arrival of Ukrainians escaping the Russian invasion in 2022 – with divergent responses. German admission law placed Syrian migrants into the standard system for asylum-seekers, creating an institutional overload due to the hundreds of thousands entering the system at once. In contrast, because of the activation of the Temporary Protection Directive at the EU-level, Germany admitted Ukrainians under a special legal status, granting them the right to work and relative freedom of movement (Council Directive 2001/55/EC of 20 July 2001). Societally, Syrians were met with *Willkommenskultur* (culture of welcome) before being viewed by the German public more sceptically, largely in relation to security concerns. Ukrainians, too, were met with a solidaristic German population, before being viewed more sceptically, in part because of perceived economic wellbeing. Despite the divergence between the exact responses to Syrian and Ukrainian refugee cohorts, in both cases, refugees were initially welcomed by Germany before being cast in a negative light.

This dissertation aims to trace how policy, discourse and aesthetics operate collectively to shape refugee reception in Germany, doing so through the matrix of German public opinion, quantitative indicators and policy responses during the 2015 Syrian refugee crisis and the 2022 Ukrainian refugee crisis. While existing literature has covered the crises individually, the regime of migration governance in Germany as a general system of exclusion has yet to be addressed in a way that is flexible enough to account for differences in the reception of refugees and systematic enough to draw parallels between the reception of separate refugee cohorts. Before moving further, it is important to provide a chronology of Germany's migration governance and relevant historical events.

Migration Governance and Context, 2014-2024

Following the post-war reestablishment of West Germany (BRD), a significant number of guest-worker migrants were admitted over time. This migration wave was followed by another swell at the time of reunification, partially as a result of the migration of ethnic Germans into the newly reunified state. However, Germany's most significant interactions with migration, quantitatively, occurred from 2010 onwards (see Figure 1).

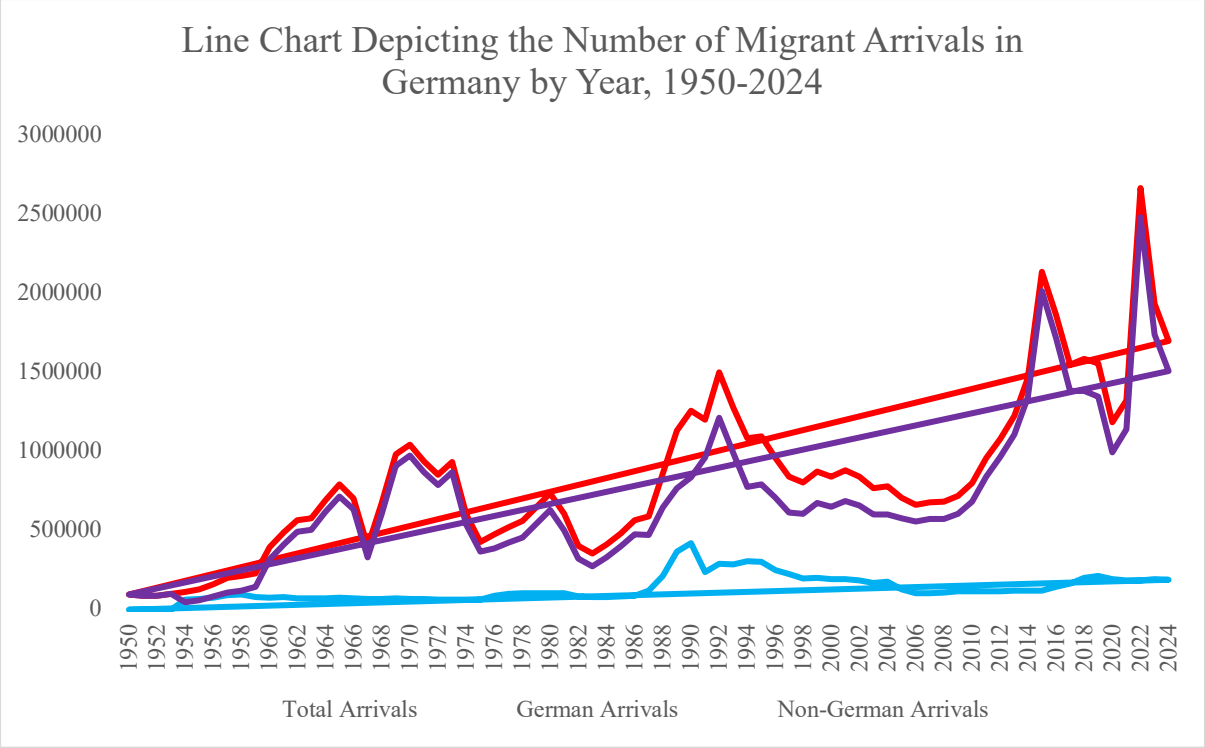

Figure 1: Migrant arrivals in Germany, 1950-2024 (Destatis, 2025a).

In the aftermath of the advent of the Syrian Civil War, millions of Syrians (and others from the Middle East and North Africa (MENA) region) began fleeing toward Europe. The summer of 2015, when the Merkel government opened Germany to these asylum seekers, witnessed a period of Willkommenskultur, whereby Germans took pride in their "humanitarian" acceptance of refugees from the MENA region. Yet, simultaneous to the Willkommenskultur attitude prevalent among Germans, the government relied upon a familiar regulation to control the movement and distribution of asylum seekers throughout Germany, the '*Residenzpflicht*'[1] (Asylgesetz 1992 §56, §85; Schuster, 2003: 248).

The Willkommenskultur period faded following the 2016 New Year's Eve attacks in Cologne ("the 2016 Cologne attack"), when multiple groups of men – appearing to be non-native Germans – sexually assaulted tens of women. This attack left Germany reeling and was detrimental for the development of solidarity with migrants from the MENA region. Since the 2016 Cologne attack, right-wing extremist organisations – including the Alternative für Deutschland (AfD) party and PEGIDA[2] – have become gradually more popular in Germany (The Federal Returning Officer, 2025). Simultaneously, those refugees arriving in and around 2015 have come to be described as "bad" migrants (see Chapter 2 for more about the "good" and "bad" migrant myths). Since 2023, especially, refugees from this cohort have been accused of harbouring widespread antisemitism, offending the sensibilities of Germans and "proving" their lack of cultural integration.

[1] The *Residenzpflicht* is 'a duty to reside in a particular area' imposed on most 'asylum-seekers' in Germany, 'who may be fined if they breach its regulations' (Schuster, 2003: 248).
[2] PEGIDA is the shorthand name of the anti-migrant movement officially referred to as 'Patriotic Europeans Against the Islamization of the Occident' (Heckmann, 2014: 14).

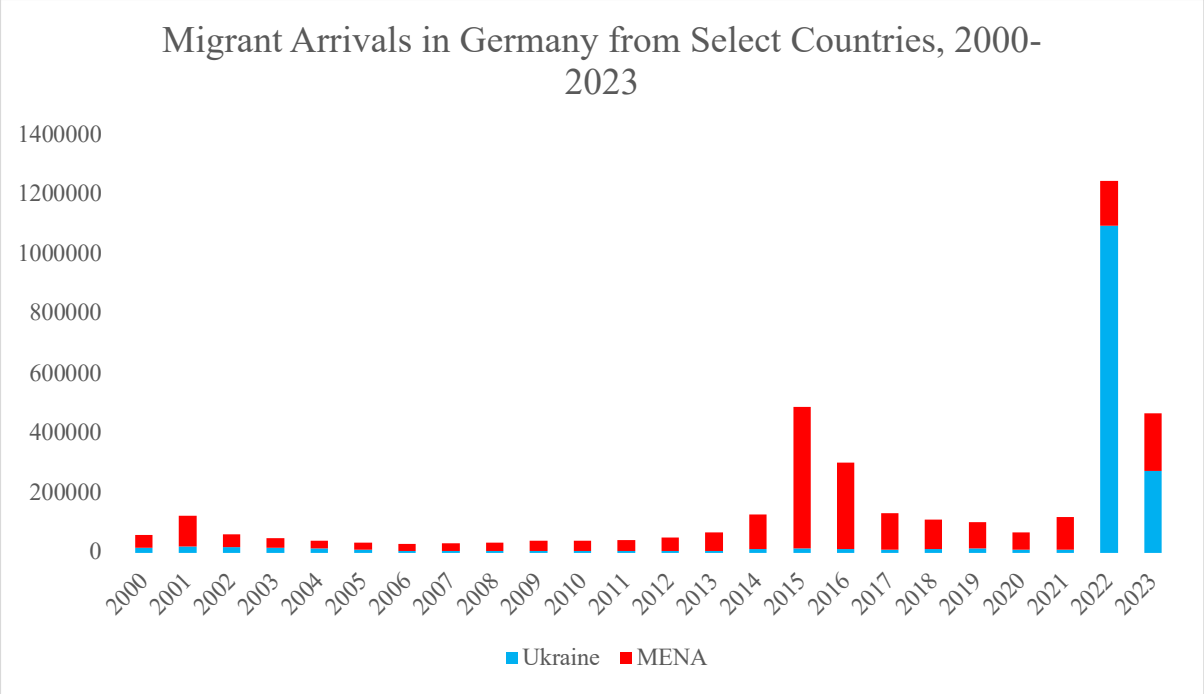

Figure 2: Migrant arrivals in Germany from select countries[3], 2000-2023 (Destatis, 2025b).

In February of 2022, Russian forces invaded Ukraine, violating a litany of 'international treaties' and 'warfare customs' (Fedorenko and Fedorenko, 2022: 8, 23). The invasion of Ukraine led 'to the large-scale extermination of Ukrainians on their territory', generating one of Europe's most significant refugee crises since the 1990s (see Figure 2; Fedorenko and Fedorenko, 2022: 33). Russian forces have been recorded 'brutally' killing and plundering Ukrainian 'civilians' and committing war crimes including 'extrajudicial executions, rape, torture, kidnapping [and] looting' (Fedorenko and Fedorenko, 2022: 25, 34). Entire Ukrainian cities, including 'Mariupol, Chernihiv, […] Bucha, and others', have been more than 70% destroyed by the war, and dozens of culturally significant buildings and monuments have been damaged or destroyed (Fedorenko and Fedorenko, 2022: 31-32). The war has led to the implementation of martial law across the entire country (Fedorenko and Fedorenko, 2022: 32). Considering these atrocities, the EU activated the Temporary Protection Directive, allowing Member States to offer protection and rights to Ukrainians (Council Directive 2001/55/EC of 20 July 2001). Paralleling the arrival of Syrians in the summer of 2015, Ukrainians were initially welcomed in Germany along "humanitarian" lines.

Over time, however, solidarity among native Germans with Ukrainian refugees has waned; Ukrainians have been 'targeted' and their 'existence' as refugees has been 'challenged' (Interview with Sabine Hess, 2025). Challenges to Ukrainians' refugeehood have primarily occurred as native Germans witness Ukrainian refugees in (relatively) stable economic conditions, as compared to other migrants (*e.g.*, owning a BMW) (Interview with Steven Vertovec, 2025). Accordingly, Ukrainians are increasingly being seen as damaging to Germany's welfare and economic system; While Syrians initially served as a "bad" migrant foil for the incoming "good" Ukrainian migrants in 2022, Ukrainians are gradually transitioning from being characterised as the "good" to the "bad" migrant themselves – a phenomenon to be explored in later chapters. Legal changes have followed social conceptualisations of "good" and "bad" migrants; while, initially, Ukrainian refugees were not

[3] In this graph, MENA includes the following countries: Algeria, Egypt, Iran, Iraq, Israel, Jordan, Kuwait, Lebanon, Libya, Morocco, Saudi Arabia, Syria, Tunisia, Turkey, United Arab Emirates and Yemen.

subjected to the Residenzpflicht or work restrictions, the German government now plans to abolish the ability for Ukrainians to receive social benefits without employment (Kopp and Judith, 2025). In sum, between 2014 and 2024, two refugee waves hit Germany. In both, the respective refugee cohorts were initially welcomed, before later being perceived as "negative" for Germany.

Looking Ahead

With this chronology in mind, particularly focusing on the parallels between the governance of Syrian and Ukrainian refugee cohorts in Germany, a number of questions arise: (1) how can one conceptualise the pattern of migration politics in Germany; (2) how does the news media impact the pattern of migration governance in Germany; and (3) is the pattern of migration politics in Germany systematic enough to reveal parallels between receptions of different refugee cohorts, yet flexible enough to reflect differences in those receptions? These are the questions that this dissertation attempts to answer through the evaluation of the "Constructive Cycle of Migrant Legitimacy" (see Figure 3), a theoretical framework attempting to document recurring patterns of migration governance in Germany. In evaluating my theoretical framework, I have utilised a mixed-methods strategy, combining qualitative, interpretivist research with quantitative research: conducting interviews with on-the-ground experts, analysing media discourse as a cultural barometer and reviewing quantitative, open-source data to test native Germans' perceptions of refugees versus reality.

This study engages with scholars like Anya Topolski, whose work states that academics 'cannot understand European racism, past or present, without making the [racialisation of religious groups] visible' (2020: 71) and Billy Holzberg *et al.*, whose work states that German press discourses construct the "bad" migrant along frames of 'economic productivity' and 'gender relations' (2018: 534-546). It also supports the critiques of securitisation and integration discourses made by Ayelet Banai and Regina Kreide (2016) and Sebastian Braun and Tina Nobis (2019), respectively. The theoretical framework employed by this study attempts to combine the dimensions discussed in existing scholarship into one framework, aiming to describe recurring cycles of migrant politics in Germany (see Figure 3).

This dissertation is structured as follows. In Chapter 2, I review the existing literature on German migration policy, the racialisation of migrant groups, the "good" migrant myth and the role of historical memory and discuss the theoretical framework guiding my analysis. In Chapter 3, I conduct an in-depth review of the methodological choices made in my dissertation. In Chapter 4, I analyse media discourse in Germany, using the language of mass media outlets as a cultural barometer for German public opinion. In Chapter 5, I discuss the role of aesthetic proximity – or the degree to which migrants are perceived as similar to native Germans based on clothing, mannerisms, language use, accents, religious symbols, *et cetera* – on Germans' reception of migrants. In Chapter 6, I explore how German bureaucracy constructs discriminatory boundaries around "belonging" in Germany. In Chapter 7, I close with a brief reflection on the scope, findings and implications of my dissertation.

2. Theoretical Framework and Literature Review

This dissertation investigates Germany's differential responses to Ukrainian and Syrian refugees in the 21st century. To contextualise and interpret these responses, it is essential to establish a theoretical foundation before proceeding onto empirical analysis. A significant body of literature explores German responses to migration waves; this study builds on the existing scholarship by proposing a cyclical understanding of 21st-century German migration politics and by including the Ukrainian refugee crisis, which because of its recency has not been covered extensively in the literature.

To provide a critical overview and synthesis of the relevant literature, this chapter is organised into four thematic sections. The first discusses the literature on German governmental and societal responses to migration, tracing historical patterns together with contemporary developments. The second engages with constructivist literature on racialisation and belonging, which forms a central theoretical pillar of this dissertation. The third considers the debates around integration outcomes and the enduring myth of the "good" migrant in Germany, together with the ascendence of right-wing extremism. Finally, the fourth reviews the scholarship at the intersections of Islam, Holocaust memorialisation and cultural conflict, especially highlighting how antisemitism and Islamophobia shape contemporary attitudes toward refugee cohorts and "belonging" in Germany.

Together, these thematic components establish a framework for analysing the active relationship between race, religion and belonging in Germany. By synthesising insights across these domains, this dissertation aims to advance scholarly understanding of the complex interplay between racial and religious categories in shaping public and governmental responses to migration.

Governmental and Societal Reactions

The post-war trajectory of migration policy in Germany can be characterised by a slowly increasing openness to perceived outsiders. Yet, at every juncture where conceptualisations of belonging in Germany have been challenged, both governmental and societal reactions have oscillated between acceptance of migrants – either as pragmatic necessity or through a humanitarian saviour framing – and counter-movements seeking to demonise the incoming migrant group.

The modern German state – at the time, the BRD – began interacting with migration through the so-called "guest worker" programme, beginning in 1961 with the signature 'of the recruitment agreement for labour' with Turkey (Şen, 2003: 208-209). The labour migration of Turks to Germany officially concluded in 1973, 'when Germany was hit by the oil crisis…and faced a downturn in its economy'; at this point, the BRD's Turkish population 'had reached 910,500' (Şen, 2003: 209). As labour migration programmes ended and Turks in Germany realised that 'the economic situation…would not have allowed a comfortable life in Turkey', they began to develop 'long-term' plans for 'permanent settlement' in Germany (Şen, 2003: 211-212). Accordingly, although official labour migration programmes ended, the migration of Turks to Germany 'continued for…two decades through family reunification' opportunities (Şen, 2003: 211). Germany's next sharp influx of migration occurred following 'the reunification of Germany' and the broader fall of Warsaw Pact regimes across eastern Europe (Şen, 2003: 214). In response, Germany witnessed one of the most intense waves of xenophobic violence since the fall of the Nazi regime, with 'racial attacks' becoming frequent, especially targeting shelters for refugees (Şen, 2003: 214; Schuster, 2003: 247).

Explaining how historical patterns led to the Germans negative reactions to migration in the 1990s, Rogers Brubaker traces the development of German nationhood, identifying how the emergence of a unified German state aligned with conceptions of German nationhood as 'an irreducibly particular *Volksgemeinschaft*'[4] (1992: 1). German nationhood was thus – especially prior to the 21st-century naturalisation reforms – an 'ethnocultural' fact (Brubaker, 1992: 1). Because "belonging" to the German polity was decided on ethnocultural lines, the German government thought it futile to attempt to "integrate" non-Germans into the polity and thus were characterised as 'differentialist' towards migrants (Brubaker, 1992: 1). Yet, the differentialist dynamics that Brubaker (1992) identified changed in the aftermath of reforms to German naturalisation laws in the 2000s.

In January 2000, the German government made significant reforms to its naturalisation law, specifically aimed to increase labour market participation within its large Turkish population (Özyürek, 2023: 14). The naturalisation reforms made 'it easier for individuals residing long-term in Germany and their children to eventually claim German citizenship' (Özyürek, 2023: 14). However, the reform still prohibited those claiming German citizenship through naturalisation from holding dual citizenship in most cases. Friedrich Heckmann's report on German perspectives on migration follows the naturalisation reforms, recounting the German government's unwillingness to recognise Germany's emergent status as a country of migration through the 1990s and 2000s (2016: 2-3). Naturalisation policies exemplified debates within Germany's governmental structures about the extent to which the emerging class of migrants could "become" German (Heckmann, 2016: 2-3). Alongside his observations of governmental reactions to migration, Heckmann highlights the significant wave of 'xenophobic attacks' targeting refugees in the 1990s, drawing parallels with societal hostilities in the 2010s, whereby refugees and volunteers were targeted with 'hate speech' and 'arson' (2016: 3-13). Significantly, the ascendance of anti-migration groups like PEGIDA illustrate dangerous counter-movements in response to challenges to established notions of "belonging" (Heckmann, 2016: 14).

Further critiquing German reactions to migration in the 1990s is Liza Schuster, whose journal article shows how Eastern European migrants in the 1990s were discursively framed as economic threats, leading to increased attacks on asylum hostels (2003: 242, 247-248). Eastern Europeans, at a time in which Germany 'was faced with the costs and challenges of reunification' were thought by the German government to be threats to the survival of the welfare state and were framed as 'unbearable' (Schuster, 2003: 242). Aligning with Heckmann's reports of 'xenophobic attacks' (2016: 3-13), Shuster recounts the 'attacks' on 'hostels' housing asylum seekers 'by local mobs' (2003: 247-248). She also notes that, as of the publishing of her article, asylum seekers still residing in hostels 'continue to face abuse and violence' (Shuster, 2003: 247-248).

Building on Brubaker (1992), Heckmann (2016) and Schuster (2003), Daniel Drewski and Jürgen Gerhards examine the German government's framing of refugee admission through humanitarian discourse (2024a: 101-116; 2024b: 1-14). During the crisis in the summer of 2015, the German government framed its responses to Syrian refugees as humanitarian in nature and took pride in the outpouring of solidarity for refugees, believing such solidarity stemmed from Germany's role as a humanitarian role model (Drewski and Gerhards, 2024a: 101-116). In its framing of Germany as a humanitarian saviour, the state simultaneously cast refugees as needing saving; it failed to acknowledge or legitimise the rights of refugees, for instance, to cultural autonomy, expecting them instead to show gratitude for the support of the

[4] The German term *Volksgemeinschaft* refers to a homogenous racial community based around "the people".

German state (Drewski and Gerhards, 2024a: 101-116; Drewski and Gerhards, 2024b: 1-14). Furthermore, the government's "humanitarian saviour" framing of Germany often failed to account for the needs of refugees to work, learn German and achieve stability, especially in the case of Syrian refugees arriving in and around 2015 (Drewski and Gerhards, 2024b: 1-14). Though their critique is useful in grasping German self-perception during refugee crises, Drewski and Gerhards (2024a; 2024b) fail to account for the fact that similar rhetoric used at the point of refugee admission (*e.g.*, humanitarianism) by the German government has led to vastly different regimes of migration governance and exclusion along different discursive lines for Syrian and Ukrainian refugees. The discursive discrepancy between the exclusion of Syrian and Ukrainian refugees suggests that the German government's discourse cannot alone fully explain the exclusion of refugees in Germany.

This collection of literature provides a vital foundation for understanding Germany's shift from labour migration to humanitarian migration, revealing persistent contradictions in how the German government frames its responses to migration and societal reactions to the same events. The literature also reveals that institutional admission discourses only partially explain processes of exclusion within migration governance. Germany's responses to Syrian and Ukrainian refugees, then, are not isolated, but rather are embedded moments in a trajectory of migration governance shaped both by institutional discourse and societal reaction.

Constructivist Theories of Racialisation and Belonging

Constructivism offers scholars a uniquely powerful framework for understanding the processes of racialisation and the construction of belonging. In its broadest definition, constructivism – as coined by Nicholas Greenwood Onuf in 1989 – contends that so-called "social facts" are made by human action, as opposed to "brute facts" that do not depend for their existence on human action but rather are phenomena of human condition' (Searle, 1995: 49, cited in Behravesh, 2011). In other words, constructivism argues that the world around us is shaped by social facts, which are constructed through human agency.

Lauren Stokes' *Fear of the Family* sharpens positivist accounts tracing the development of German migration policy through its application of constructivist theory to connect the reactions by the German government to waves of migration and societal backlash against migrant cohorts (2022: 4-8). Insofar as the BRD interacted with migration as a necessity during the guest worker period (from the 1950s through the 1970s), the family unit became a discursive site where racialised difference between the native German and the migrant "other" was produced (Stokes, 2022: 4). Constructivist racialisation theory, Stokes argues, most accurately explains divergent reactions to migrant cohorts (2022: 7). While the family unit had served as a site to produce artificial, racialised difference between the migrant "other" and the native German, increasingly – and especially since the 1990s – religion has replaced the family unit as the site of this differentiation, with religious difference now more salient across both the religious south and west and the atheist east (Stokes, 2022: 8).

As demonstrated by Stokes (2022), constructivist theoretical frameworks allow for an analysis of the process of racialisation, one of the concepts central to constructivist accounts of migration. Social theorists influenced by constructivism such as Robert Miles and Steve Garner expound on Stokes' view by exploring how racialisation does not rely solely on phenotypical differences between individuals (e.g., skin colour), as exemplified by the racialisation of the 'Irish in nineteenth-century Britain and the Eastern European Jews in early twentieth-century England' (Miles, 1987, cited in Garner, 2010: 21). Rather, class and 'race' intertwine intimately 'to attach…specific…racial meanings to a…group's collective behaviour' (Garner, 2010: 21).

This is what is meant by racialisation: the ascription of racial meaning to a group that isn't *necessarily* characterised by phenotypical differences from other groups along the colour line. Racialisation thus serves as a powerful framework for understanding the construction of belonging in Germany.

Racialisation is deeply entwined with the construction of migrants as *cultural* outsiders in Germany, and the process of racialisation occurs along many discursive lines, one being the use of securitisation discourse, as identified by Ayelet Banai and Regina Kreide (2016: 904-911). Migrants are positioned by securitisation discourses as being 'a danger to public order, to living peacefully together, to the welfare state system, to the labour market and to cultural identity', specifically identifying Muslim migrants as 'adverse to German society and its values' (Banai and Kreide, 2016: 907, 909). Insofar as Islam has been constructed to be antithetical to German culture and values systems, Christianity and Judaism have been co-opted as 'belonging' to the so-called German 'Judeo-Christian tradition' (Banai and Kreide, 2016: 909). The use of securitisation discourse against Muslims in Germany has definitively led to Muslims facing significant 'internal cultural and social boundaries', culminating in their 'exclusion from equal citizenship' (Banai and Kreide, 2016: 911).

Anne-Kathrin Will's analysis of legal categorisation within German migration law (2019: 540-551) reflects the ethnic exclusion identified by Banai and Kreide (2016). Will identifies how categories in migration law, such as *Migrationshintergrund*, have taken on meanings of their own, reinforcing securitisation discourse and echoing racialised logics reminiscent of Nazi-era racial classifications, lacking legal or logical coherence (2019: 544, 551). Taken together, Will (2019: 540-551) and Banai and Kreide (2016: 904-911) argue that German "belonging" remains tethered to ethnic understandings of membership.

The article by Kirk Bansak *et al.* provides empirical support for these constructivist theoretical claims through its analysis of public preferences toward asylum seekers in Germany (2016: 217-221). They find that German public attitudes toward asylum seekers are coloured by perceptions of migrants' 'potential economic contributions, humanitarian concerns about the deservingness of their claims, and anti-Muslim bias' (Bansak *et al.*, 2016: 217-218). Critically, these categories rest on assumptions; it is impossible to predict a migrant's future economic contributions to Germany, for example, or to definitively know a migrant's religious identity without direct inquiry. As such, migrants are bound to qualities that they might not ascribe themselves, implying that migrants – be they white Europeans or Arabs – can be racialised solely based on perceived signals of divergence from societal norms. Furthermore, these preferences are identified as generally representative of a consensus among Germans, regardless of their political associations, age, educational attainment and economic health (Bansak *et al.*, 2016: 218).

As exemplified through this section of the literature, migrants are not simply excluded based on racial phenotypes in Germany. Rather, they are actively constructed as cultural outsiders through frameworks of religion and legality. This theoretical concept aids in explaining why discursive differences, especially in the news media, between Syrian and Ukrainian refugees exist; while both Syrians and Ukrainians have been marked as cultural outsiders in Germany, this has occurred using different terms. Thus, constructivist theories offer vital tools for analysing how the process of racialisation operates in Germany, helping to explain the deeper sociocultural dynamics shaping public attitudes toward refugees.

The "Good" Migrant Myth, Right-Wing Extremist Mobilisation and Public Perception

Migration scholarship frequently emphasises the discursive shaping of societal barriers to belonging. As previously discussed, Banai and Kreide (2016) interpret securitisation discourse as a gatekeeping mechanism in Germany, which, through linkages between Islam and security risk, limits Muslims' access to social inclusion (2016: 904-911). Likewise, Sebastian Braun and Tina Nobis identify integration discourse as playing a definitive role in German migration politics, moralising migrants as "good" or "bad" based on their perceived level of societal integration (2019: 187-194). Accordingly, assumptions about migrants embedded within securitisation and integration discourses rest on the problematic conflation of social cohesion with migrants' "cultural assimilation". This equivalence reinforces notions of belonging in Germany; migrants who pose an (imagined) security threat, retain markers of their native culture or are perceived as not sufficiently "economically integrated" are perceived as incapable of ever truly belonging in Germany.

The literature illustrates the tension faced by racialised "Muslim" migrants in Germany; migrants denied access to work and mobility rights on the grounds of "security concerns" are later criticised for their supposed "lack" of integration – a process from which they were structurally excluded. Such tensions link directly to broader social narratives conflating inactivity with deviance, thus both constructing and entrenching the figure of the "bad" migrant.

This dichotomy is unpacked by Billy Holzberg *et al.*, who analyse German press discourses that construct figures of "bad" migrants along three frames: 'economic productivity, state security and gender relations' (2018: 534-546). Press discourses reinforce 'racialised' stereotypes of migrants 'as under-qualified, lazy and costly for the state' (Holzberg *et al.*, 2018: 541-542). Media constructions of a dichotomy between the "bad" and the "good" migrants function as a tool that justifies selective solidarity from the general population, while also reinforcing and shaping public attitudes and policy formation in ways that mirror broader patterns identified throughout migration literature.

Irina Molodikova and Anna Lyalina, expounding on the "good" migrant myth's role in shaping public opinion, demonstrate how right-wing extremist movements in Germany – namely the AfD and PEGIDA – have instrumentalised growing anti-migrant sentiment (2017: 60-72). Anti-migrant sentiments are driven by the perception that migrants pose an 'economic' or identity-based threat to Germany (Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2014; Hainmueller and Hiscox, 2010; Tingley, 2013, cited in Molodikova and Lyalina, 2017: 61). Electoral data further support the authors' claim that rising anti-migrant sentiment contributed to increased support for right-wing extremist parties; the AfD, for example, more than doubled their electoral support between 2014 and 2017 (Forschungsgruppe Wahlen, 2017, cited in Molodikova and Lyalina, 2017: 68). Additionally, quantitative data show that in the aftermath of the 2016 Cologne attack, over 60% of Germans associated 'terrorism with migrants' (Pew Research Centre, 2016, cited in Molodikova and Lyalina, 2017: 66). The post-Willkommenskultur period, according to Molodikova and Lyalina, was marked by a discursive shift which recast Syrian refugees as "bad" migrants (2017: 60-72). The Willkommenskultur-period notion – fuelled by native German humanitarian discourse and self-perception – which cast Syrian refugees as "good" through innocence and neediness framing began to morph throughout 2016, culminating in the branding of Syrian refugees as culturally incompatible with German identity and the ultimate racialisation of "Muslims" along religious, rather than phenotypic, frames.

Bastian Vollmer and Serhat Karakayali develop the anti-migrant societal calcification section of the Constructive Cycle of Migrant Legitimacy (see Figure 3) by tracing historical patterns, identifying that the discursive shift faced by "Muslims" in 2016 – whereby Syrian refugees moved from the space of the "good" migrant to the "bad" migrant – forms part of a pattern in German migration history (2018: 118-139). Continuing since the guest worker period in Germany, fears of 'uncontrolled movement' have persisted (Karakayali, 2008; Schönwälder, 2001, cited in Vollmer and Karakayali, 2018: 118). Vollmer and Karakayali, echoing the findings of Molodikova and Lyalina (2017), argue that the 2016 Cologne attack constituted a turning point for Syrian refugees (2018: 129-130); afterwards, German social media became 'flooded with anti-immigration and outright xenophobic and racist indignations (Vollmer and Karakayali, 2018: 129-130). Following the 2016 Cologne attack, Syrian refugees – as well as others perceived as being "Muslim migrants" – were increasingly framed as 'dangerous' (Vollmer and Karakayali, 2018: 130). State responses, including the discouragement of sexual relationships between 'German girls' and male refugees and the promotion of the translation of the German Basic Law into Arabic, exemplify the influence of securitisation discourse (Vollmer and Karakayali, 2018: 130). The discursive shift, documented by both Vollmer and Karakayali (2018) and Molodikova and Lyalina (2017), contributed to the exclusion of Syrian refugees, and other MENA-origin migrants more generally, from German belonging, echoing anti-migrant patterns long at play in Germany.

The literature emphasises that the "good" migrant myth is discursively powerful; it provides for selective inclusion while justifying widespread exclusion. Should migrants retain cultural distinctiveness, fail to adapt to German social and economic expectations or fail to "integrate" perfectly, they will be cast as "bad" in public discourse, influencing policy and public attitudes greatly. The wholesale casting of migrant cohorts as "bad" also bears on electoral results, fostering the co-optation of securitisation and integration discourses by right-wing extremists in the AfD (for election results, see The Federal Returning Officer, 2025). Critically, as this dissertation will later argue, the simultaneous occurrences of Ukrainians transitioning into occupying the "bad" migrant space in public discourse and the electoral rise of the AfD – a party with controversial links to the Russian regime (Wood, 2020) – could bode poorly for the continuing reception and tolerance of Ukrainians in Germany. Furthermore, the "good" migrant myth entrenches already-dominant racialisation logics in Germany, contributing further to the reproduction of cycles of migrant inclusion and exclusion. Moreover, the literature reinforces the notion that belonging in Germany remains fixed to conformity with dominant cultural norms.

Religion, Holocaust Memorialisation and the Racialised Nation

Holocaust memorialisation constitutes a foundational component of German identity. Accordingly, much of the recent literature at the intersection of migration, religion and cultural conflict in Germany reflects on the moral exclusion of non-ethnic Germans from Holocaust memorialisation and the moral hierarchisation of antisemitism and racism by Germans.

In *Subcontractors of Guilt: Holocaust Memory and Muslim Belonging in Postwar Germany*, Esra Özyürek argues that Germans' focus on stereotypes of Muslim antisemitism functions as an absolution from Germans' historic guilt (2023: 1-209). By 'subcontracting' the guilt of antisemitism onto Muslims, the German public psychologically absolves themselves of tensions between national pride and shame, inclusion and exclusion of migrants and 'universalism and particularism' (Özyürek, 2023: 21). By focusing on the phenomenon of Muslim antisemitism in Germany, migrants of Arab and Turkish background are framed 'as morally inferior to repentant white Germans' (Özyürek, 2023: 20). Damani Partridge also

identifies gaps in German memorialisation culture, articulating how German histories of the Holocaust and expressions of guilt fail to account for modern German racism or the similarities between the perpetration of the Holocaust and modern genocides, ethnic cleansing and everyday racism (2010: 820-850). Germans are thus able to ignore modern racist behaviours and patterns by imagining the Holocaust – and racism more generally – as a phenomenon of the past (Partridge, 2010: 826, 834-835). Taken together, Özyürek (2023) and Partridge (2010) emphasise the profound fallacies in German memorialisation culture and how those fallacies are co-opted at the expense of Germany's Muslim population, who are excluded from German "belonging" on moral grounds.

Another discursive trend at the crossroads of religion and race in Europe is identified by Anya Topolski, who articulates how the term "Judeo-Christian" functions as simultaneously antisemitic and Islamophobic, both erasing the pain caused to Jews in Europe for centuries and the storied history of Muslims in Europe (2020: 71-90). She traces the genealogy of the term "Judeo-Christian" to nineteenth-century Germany, whereby it functioned to socially discriminate against Jews, Muslims and Catholics and to racialise exclude Jews and Muslims from the "European identity" (Topolski, 2020: 74). She then moves to analyse modern uses of "Judeo-Christian", focusing on the debates surrounding its prospective inclusion in the EU Constitution between 2003 and 2005 (Topolski, 2020: 82-83). The proposal to include text specifying Europe as having a "Judeo-Christian" heritage simultaneously erased the centuries of persecution that Jews faced at the hands of various European states and the storied history of Muslims in the Iberian Peninsula and the Balkans; in contemporary contexts, the term is mobilised in inherently antisemitic and Islamophobic ways to frame Europe (Topolski, 2020: 82-84). In the twenty-first-century, Topolski argues, the term "Judeo-Christian" includes Jews only in 'symbolic' terms, distils Judaism into a form assimilated into Christian European norms, excludes Muslims from the mosaic of European history and thought, racialises both Jews and Muslims as "outsiders" in Europe and plays Jews 'off against Muslims' through their symbolic and material non-inclusion in the 'European family' (2020: 87).

While Topolski (2020) identifies an instance of religious terminology positively discriminating – or, identifying a trait which one *has* which makes them an "outsider" – against Muslims and Jews in Europe, J. Kameron Carter offers a theological account of this dynamic, arguing that Christian theological discourse participated in the racialisation of Jews and Muslims by negative discriminating against them (2008: 1-380). Carter opens by identifying that, alongside Jews – who were racialised 'in contrast to Western Christians' – Christians themselves were, 'with the important assistance of the discourses of Christian theology and philosophy', 'subtly' racialised as well (2008: 4). Yet, the racialisation of European Christians served primarily to negatively discriminate against and identify "outsiders" in Europe, particularly Muslims and Jews. Carter also works alongside Topolski (2020) to criticise the "Judeo-Christian" myth by recounting the historical positioning of Jews and Christians as inherently antagonistic throughout much of the pre-1945 European history (2008: 4).

Definitively connecting European religious cleavages to constructivist accounts of migration politics, Matti Bunzl identifies European Islamophobia 'as a means of fortifying Europe' (2005: 499-508). Mirroring the securitisation and integration discourses identified, respectively, by Banai and Kreide (2016) and Braun and Nobis (2019), Bunzl asserts that 'Islamophobia is marshalled to safeguard the future of European civilization' and that, because 'Muslims', to Europeans, 'are the bearers of a fundamentally distinct culture', they are 'essentially unassimilable' (2005: 506). In concrete terms, Bunzl shows how European Islamophobia, using securitisation and integration frames, stands as a barrier 'against Turkey's membership in the

European Union' and the 'influx of immigrants from North Africa and the Middle East' (2005: 506).

Altogether, the literature in this section emphasises how migrant exclusion in Germany has been, in the case of Syrian refugees, co-constituted through religious discourse, collective Holocaust memorialisation and discursive norms. Syrian "outsiders" have been defined in racialised religious terms; they are positioned definitively outside the community to which "ethnic Germans" belong.

Theoretical Framework

As outlined in Chapter 1, this dissertation employs a theoretical framework which attempts to conceptualise the pattern of migration politics in Germany and its degree of flexibility, and to assess the impact of the German news media on migration governance. One model for doing so is in terms of a cycle in which laws, discourse and the news media interact to produce an ever-tightening atmosphere of migration politics. For convenience, this dissertation refers to this cycle as the "Constructive Cycle of Migrant Legitimacy". While previous work has examined linear relationships between individual links in this cycle, this dissertation contributes to existing literature by proposing a cyclical model that captures the recurrent dynamics between discourse, governance and public sentiment in German migration politics. Grounded in social constructivism, this framework attempts to model the pattern of migration politics by tracing its dynamics across multiple refugee cohorts. The framework culminates in a feedback loop, wherein calcified anti-migrant sentiment re-enters the policy sphere, shaping subsequent iterations of admission law. This recursive process enables the reproduction, and occasional reconfiguration, of exclusionary regimes of migration politics. The analysis in this dissertation will map the experiences of 21st-century refugees in Germany based on the directionality identified by this cycle, but importantly, will not be evaluating this framework against others.

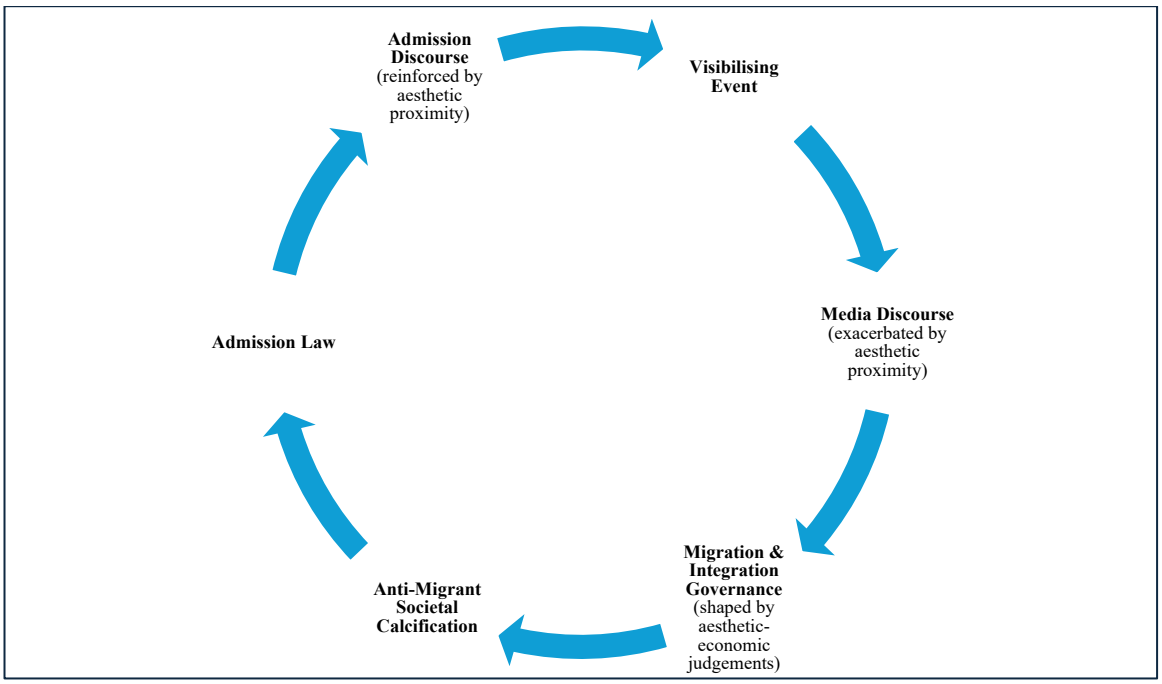

Figure 3: The Constructive Cycle of Migrant Legitimacy, beginning with "Admission Law" and ending with "Anti-Migrant Societal Calcification", before looping back to "Admission Law".

To clarify the framework shown in Figure 3, each of its core terms, as they appear, are defined below. "Admission law" refers to the rules and regulations guiding the admission (or rejection) of migrants upon arrival in Germany. "Admission discourse" refers to the discursive practices that justify and frame the admission laws applied. A "visibilising event" is any event – or any perception of an event – that functionally visibilises migrants after arrival. This can include events such as terrorist attacks or perceptions that migrants are 'stealing' from the welfare system. The key condition is that the "visibilising event" highlights the presence of a migrant cohort, rendering them visible and subject to scrutiny. "Media discourse" describes the discourse used by news media organisations to frame migrants and visibilising events (*e.g.*, coverage of terrorist attacks, coverage of migration). "Migration & Integration Governance" is the regime of laws and regulations in place for migrants who have been admitted into Germany (*e.g.*, the Residenzpflicht). "Anti-Migrant Societal Calcification" refers to the entrenchment of anti-migrant sentiment in the public sphere.

The literature robustly supports the directionality proposed by this framework. For example, the causal direction from "admission law" to "admission discourse" is supported by Roger Zetter, who says that 'bureaucratic labels both reproduce themselves in the prevailing political discourse and popular vocabulary and are instrumental in further politicising the label' (2007: 184). The next link in the cycle, from "admission discourse" to "visibilising event", is supported by Liisa Malkki, who says that admission discourses 'tend to silence' migrants because such discourses 'universalise' them (1996: 378). Other supporting literature for the causal directionality portrayed by Figure 3 includes the works by Seth Holmes and Heide Castañeda (from "visibilising event" to "media discourse"), who say that visibilised migrants 'are overtly and subtly portrayed' by the media 'as a threat' (2016: 18), Thierry Balzacq (from "media discourse" to "migration and integration governance"), who says that security-based governance problems are constructed 'through discursive' frames (2010: 19), Didier Fassin (from "migration and integration governance" to "anti-migrant societal calcification"), who says that 'moral sentiments…nourish' contemporary political 'discourses and…practices' (2011: 18) and finally, Willem Schinkel (from "anti-migrant societal calcification" to "admission law"), who says that 'models of immigrant integration and citizenship' get tightened as a result of 'cultural-communication elements' (2017: 82). Each of these pieces of scholarship fits within my cyclical framework, supporting at least one of its linkages (see Figure 3).

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In sum, the literature on migration governance, racialisation and discursive framings of religion, securitisation and integration reveals how Germany's response to migration is informed and constructed. The scholarship has shown how the "good" migrant myth, religious racialisation and hierarchisation and memorialisation culture are interlinked in a system of differentiation and selective inclusion. Constructivist theoretical tools prove most effective when interrogating the differential treatment between refugee cohorts in Germany. This scholarship lends us several key discoveries that are directly relevant to this project: (1) racialisation is not a phenotypic phenomenon, (2) discursive framings play a constitutive role in excluding refugee cohorts, (3) securitisation and integration discourses are central in their impact on Syrians and Ukrainian refugee cohorts, (4) the ascendance of right-wing extremism in Germany promotes exclusionary discourse toward migrants, (5) upon arrival, those perceived as "Muslim" are faced with social exclusion which is exacerbated by German Islamophobia and (6) Ukrainian refugees are beginning to occupy the "bad" migrant space in German public discourse.

While the relevant literature to this dissertation is extensive, this work aims to bring together theoretical insights and empirical observation in a novel framework, tracing how law and discourse work together to stratify, legitimise and exclude refugee cohorts. This collection of scholarship and theoretical framework will colour my analysis – in the chapters that follow – of the research conducted for this dissertation, informing both the conclusions drawn and implications considered.

3. Methodology

At its core, this study interrogates 21st-century constructs of belonging in Germany through the lens of recent refugee crises. The methodological choices supporting this study are reflective of the limitations posed by any single method; whereas discourse analysis often misses critical quantitative trends, quantitative methodologies risk oversimplifying societal dynamics. Accordingly, this study adopts a mixed-methods approach, aiming to draw insights and conclusions from an integrated matrix of interpretivist news media discourse analysis and expert interviews and quantitative indicators. In so doing, this study traces how policy, discourse and aesthetics operate in tandem to shape refugee reception in Germany's political and cultural imagination.

Reflecting on both my own positionality as a non-German researcher and the limited nature of discourse analysis and quantitative indicators as individual methods, this study relies on interviews with experts across the academic, political and civil society spheres as a core part of its data. It approaches these interviews with an interpretivist methodological persuasion, attempting to use them to investigate how, although differences in the treatment of Syrian and Ukrainian refugees in Germany exist, the experiences of both cohorts are representative of the same construct of migrant exclusion in Germany. In Table 1 (see below), I have summarised the interviews I conducted for this study, censoring the names and direct affiliations of interlocutors who requested to remain anonymous[5]. I found my interlocutors by systematically searching for migration experts in the policy, research and foundation spheres, reaching out directly to 62 potential interlocutors. Although I would have liked to speak with more experts in political parties, there was no way of knowing that a snap election would be called for February 2025 when the research for this project began. Because of the snap election, many members of the Bundestag or regional party members refused to speak with me, being too busy with election campaigns or worrying that their participation could reflect poorly on positions taken in later coalition agreements.

Reference	Name	Affiliation	Position	Interview Date	Interview Location
Interlocutor A	Prof Dr Sabine Hess	Georg-August-Universität Göttingen	Professor	4 April 2025	Zoom
Interlocutor B	Anonymous	Political Foundation	Director	10 April 2025	Zoom
Interlocutor C	Tatiana Mendonça	Migrationsbeirat München	Member	11 April 2025	Munich
Interlocutor D	Prof Dr Dr hc Steven Vertovec	Max Planck Institute	Founding Director	14 April 2025	Göttingen
Interlocutor E	Dr Marie Walter-Franke	Sachverständigenrat für Integration und Migration	Researcher	15 April 2025	Berlin

[5] For more on expert interviews as a methodology, see Bogner *et al.* (2009).

Interlocutor F	Dr Ulrike Bialas	Max Planck Institute	Postdoctoral Research Fellow	15 April 2025	Berlin
Interlocutor G	Prof Dr Karen Schönwälder	Max Planck Institute	Research Group Leader	16 April 2025	Berlin
Interlocutor H	Dr Jan Schneider	Sachverständigenrat für Integration und Migration	Head of Research Unit	17 April 2025	Berlin
Interlocutor J	Carmen Romano	Migrationsbeirat München	Member	24 April 2025	Zoom
Interlocutor K	Anonymous	Research Institute	Researcher	28 April 2025	Zoom

Table 1: Critical information about each of my interlocutors and their interviews with me.

Alongside my interview-based research, I conducted a media discourse analysis across mainstream and alternative news media as a cultural barometer, aiming to better understand how different segments of German society referred to and discussed refugee groups. I selected media outlets based on two general criteria: (1) the outlet's political persuasion and (2) its popularity with segments of society as reflected by its circulation. I chose *BILD* as both a representative publication for the mainstream centre-right of German politics and as a representative for the German tabloid landscape; *BILD* is immensely popular with everyday German readers, reflected in its vast circulation. *Handelsblatt* was chosen not for its vast readership, but because it both represented an ever-present political force in Germany ("pragmatic" fiscal liberalism) and because of its popularity with highly educated centrist Germans. I chose *Der Spiegel* as reflective of weekly publications with wide appeal and as a representative for mainstream, centre-left discourse, especially among the youth. Finally, I chose *Die Tageszeitung* (*TAZ*) to represent the alternative hard left of the political spectrum found most prominently in Berlin; though its print circulation is relatively small, it has a substantial online circulation. Its readership largely consists of urban left-wing and green voters, especially those dissatisfied with mainstream centre-left politics in Germany; this segment of the population is growing in Germany, reflected by Die Linke's[6] remarkable electoral performance with young voters in 2025 (The Federal Returning Officer, 2025).

In Table 2 (see below), I have illustrated the media outlets I have chosen to analyse. After choosing outlets to analyse, I set rules around which articles I would draw data from. I decided to observe all articles published by these four outlets between 1 January 2014 and 31 December 2024 with 'Migration'[7] in the headline. I characterised each of these articles as "positive", "negative" or "neutral" in their characterisations of migration, and recorded whether each article mentioned Syrians or Ukrainians directly. Accordingly, I was able to analyse what proportion of each outlet's coverage of Ukrainian refugees and Syrian refugees, respectively, was positive, negative and neutral. I also recorded recurring phrases and words used by these outlets to describe migrants, especially noting when such phrases referred to specific cohorts[8].

[6] 'Die Linke' is a German political party which is the legal successor to the East German Socialist Unity Party. It occupies space on the German hard left, occasionally being considered left-wing extremist.
[7] The German word *Migration* is spelled the same as its English equivalent, migration.
[8] For more on media discourse analysis as a methodology, see O'Keeffe (2012).

Source	Political Perspective	Location	Print Circulation (2021)	Frequency
BILD	Centre-right	Berlin	1,150,181	Daily (except Sunday)
Handelsblatt	(Fiscal) liberal	Düsseldorf	134,191	Daily
Der Spiegel	Centre-left	Hamburg	715,498	Weekly
Die Tageszeitung	Hard left	Berlin	~42,000	Daily

Table 2: Critical information about each of the press outlets I am evaluating.

My research also utilises quantitative data in its analyses of German inclusion, belonging and migration politics. The quantitative data drawn upon by this study aids in triangulating the gaps between perception and reality, especially when comparing news media discourse (perception) and, for example, unemployment rates (reality). The quantitative data utilised for this study was sourced from the German Socio-Economic Panel (SOEP), the Federal Criminal Police Office (BKA), the European Social Survey (ESS) and Destatis, the Federal Statistical Office. This data aids in challenging dominant anti-migrant discourse reflected in the German news media landscape, implying that anti-migrant discourse is not data-driven, but is rather driven by (biased) perceptions of refugees.

Ethically, this study required careful consideration of my own positionality and the privilege inherent to the dynamic between researchers and interlocutors. While much of the ethical conundrums associated with interview-based research were mitigated by my selection of expert interlocutors (rather than, for example, refugees themselves), it was still important to secure explicit consent and prioritise clarity when speaking with my interlocutors. Furthermore, it is important to acknowledge that my interlocutors retain the right to amend their statements, findings and beliefs.

My positionality as an American-born researcher in Germany is critical to acknowledge before opening my analysis of Germany's reception of refugees. Though I was primarily raised and educated in the United States, I have experience studying and living in Germany, and I am professionally fluent in the German language. Both facts greatly increased my access to interlocutors; simply understanding, for instance, how to properly address an interlocutor in a formal tone (*i.e.*, using one's full academic title rather than their name alone) increased my perceived legitimacy among interlocutors. Speaking the language, too, allowed me increased insight into German public debates. In all, keeping in mind my positionality as a transatlantic researcher aided in my sensitivity to difference, and my history of interaction with Germany allowed me a more seamless experience conducting research across the country.

Certain limitations in my research must be acknowledged. The generalisability of this study's conclusions and implications is inherently limited to Germany and cannot be said to accurately represent other European countries, as its case studies and historical context draw entirely from Germany. Furthermore, while this study identifies a cycle with a certain directionality (see Figure 3) and provides theoretical support for that directionality, disagreements in the literature remain as to the directionality of links between policy, legal categorisation and anti-migrant discourse. Additionally, when using the filtering process described above for articles from each of the respective news media outlets, articles published by *BILD* and *Der Spiegel* skew heavily

toward the post-2022 period (see Appendix 1). Whether this is a coincidence, representative of increased coverage utilising the term 'migration' in the aftermath of the invasion of Ukraine or a problem with the database used by this study is not known. Accordingly, sample problems may exist, especially for findings from *BILD* and *Der Spiegel*. Limitations also exist in the utilisation expert interviews; having conducted interviews with expert interlocutors rather than refugees themselves, this research is two steps removed from refugees themselves. The biases and positionalities of my interlocutors should also not be ignored; it cannot be said that the interpretations and perspectives of my interlocutors represent a generalisable understanding of social mechanisms, as my interlocutors can generally be characterised as pro-migrant.

Having outlined the methodological choices made by this study and justified the adoption of a mixed-methods, interpretivist approach, this chapter has emphasised how the matrix of expert interviews, media discourse and quantitative indicators will aid in tracing how dynamics like racialisation, gender and economic biases, anti-migrant discourse and legal categorisation work in tandem to shape the reception of refugees in Germany. This chapter has also addressed the limitations present within each methodology and engaged with positionality and ethical considerations. The following chapters proceed to this study's empirical findings and theoretical analysis of how migrant cohorts have been differentially treated in Germany, and what these treatments reveal about German constructs and cycles of belonging.

4. Media Discourse and Anti-Migrant Narratives

To understand the terms on which belonging is constructed in Germany, attention must be paid to the discursive frameworks through which refugees are represented and perceived in the news media. News coverage not only shapes public sentiment but also reflects the ideational boundaries of "belonging" employed by their respective readers. This chapter presents the findings of my discourse analysis on German news media representations of migrants, focusing specifically on *BILD*, *Handelsblatt*, *Der Spiegel* and *TAZ*. Taken together, these four publications represent a wide swathe of German society, with each outlet representing distinct readerships and political orientations; accordingly, they provide a relatively holistic insight into divergent and convergent narratives about refugees that circulate within German society.

The results of my discourse analysis are presented in this chapter, which begins by providing an overview of how refugees have been framed in the German news media during the past ten years (2014-2024). The first section of this chapter also incorporates insights from my interviews and theoretical literature to interpret the findings from my discourse analysis. The second section discusses the implications of frameworks employed by news media outlets, introducing the concept of *Generalverdacht*[9]. The third section examines how securitisation discourses in German news media coverage of migration contribute to the criminalisation of refugees along both racialised and gendered axes. This chapter concludes by reflecting on the discursive role of German news media in encouraging cycles of refugee exclusion.

Media Discourse Analysis and Contrasts in Representation

To briefly recapitulate, I selected news media outlets for my discourse analysis based on their political orientations, readership demographics, circulation sizes and national prominence. Accordingly, I analysed coverage from *BILD*, *Handelsblatt*, *Der Spiegel* and *TAZ*, representing a broad cross-section of the German media landscape, ranging from populist to neoliberal in their readerships, right-wing to left-wing in their political orientations and mainstream to alternative in their editorial styles and institutional standing. Using Dow Jones Factiva, an online database accessed through the University of Cambridge, I filtered for all articles published by these outlets between 2014 and 2024 that included the word 'migration' in their headlines. This produced 53 articles from *BILD*, 78 articles from *Handelsblatt*, 68 articles from *Der Spiegel* and 105 articles from *TAZ*. Each article I analysed was originally written in German, translated into English by me and coded as having a "positive", "negative" or "neutral" tone toward refugee cohorts. I coded articles as "negative" that, in context, negatively used descriptors like 'illegal', 'irregular', 'criminals' or 'perpetrators', for example, to describe refugees. Similarly, I coded articles as "positive" that positively associated descriptors like 'overqualified' or 'victims', for example, with refugees. I coded articles that associated mixed or neutral phrasing with refugees as "neutral". I also recorded whether the articles explicitly mentioned Syrians or Ukrainians, and I extracted recurring phrases across articles from the same outlet that were used to characterise refugee cohorts (see Table 4). This process enabled me to create a comparative table (see Table 3) of the tone of articles describing refugee cohorts across outlets, thereby supporting an analysis of how discursive boundaries of "belonging" are drawn in German news media discourse.

This media discourse analysis must confront the epistemological challenge posed by the gap between the discursive content found in the news media and the perceptions held by respective audiences. Given this gap, I chose to focus specifically on repeated phrases across articles

[9] The German word 'Generalverdacht' refers to the widespread, apprehensive sentiment felt against a group of people or organisations.

within the same outlet; when readers consume media from an outlet that repeatedly uses specific descriptors in connection with refugee cohorts, it becomes increasingly likely that associations between those cohorts and those descriptors are internalised. Accordingly, the average reader of *BILD*, which connected the term 'illegal' with refugees 17 times between 2022 and 2024, is more likely to conjure the term 'illegal' when thinking about refugees than, for instance, the average reader of *TAZ*, which never used the term over the same period.

	***BILD*[10] (n=53)**			***Handelsblatt* (n=78)**			***Der Spiegel* (n=68)**			***TAZ* (n=105)**		
	+	=	-	+	=	-	+	=	-	+	=	-
Ukrainians Mentioned	0	33.3	66.7	30.8	23.1	46.2	10.5	31.6	57.9	66.7	33.3	0
Syrians Mentioned	0	0	100	23.5	41.8	35.3	39.3	10.7	50	90	10	0

Table 3: Percentage of coverage explicitly mentioning Syrians or Ukrainians from each outlet that was positive, negative and neutral (2014-2024).[11]

Migration-related coverage in *BILD* between 2014 and 2024 was broadly negative, with two-thirds of articles mentioning Ukrainians and all those mentioning Syrians exhibiting a negative tone (see Table 3). *BILD*'s coverage closely reflected the securitisation discourse critiqued by Banai and Kreide (2016), particularly through its recurrent use of the terms 'criminal', 'terror', 'perpetrators' and 'suspects' (see Table 4). *BILD* also regularly engaged in the integration discourse critiqued by Braun and Nobis (2019), especially through the use of terms like 'hostile to learning' and 'anti-integration' (see Table 4).

Over the same period, *Handelsblatt*'s coverage was more mixed; a plurality of its articles mentioning Ukrainians were negative (46.2%), whereas a plurality of those mentioning Syrians were neutral (41.8%) (see Table 3). Nevertheless, many of the recurring descriptors *Handelsblatt* associated with refugee cohorts similarly echoed securitisation discourse, particularly through the phrases 'fear', 'non-permitted', 'Islamists', 'attackers', 'danger', 'radical' and 'terrorists' (see Table 4). *Handelsblatt*'s negative coverage of migration primarily focused on the ways that refugee violent crime and exploitation of the economic system might exacerbate pressures on labour markets and economic conditions in Germany. Accordingly, the securitisation discourse employed against refugee cohorts, in context, usually painted Syrians as physical threats and Ukrainians as economic threats, a phenomenon discussed at length in later sections of this chapter.

Though *BILD* and *Handelsblatt* cater to widely different readerships, they both engage heavily in anti-migrant securitisation discourse. *BILD*'s coverage closely mirrors the perspective of many German conservatives in its openness regarding the outlet's refugee scepticism, outwardly criminalising refugee cohorts in its discourse. *Handelsblatt*'s engagement with

[10] *BILD* includes coverage published by *BILD-Germany*, *BILD Berlin-Brandenburg*, *BILD Frankfurt Rhein-Main*, *BILD Hamburg*, *BILD Hannover*, *BILD Mecklenburg-Vorpommern*, *BILD München*, *BILD Plus*, *BULD Rheinland-Pfalz*, *BILD-Ruhrgebiet*, *BILD Saarland*, *BILD Sachsen*, *BILD Sachsen-Anhalt*, *BILD Stuttgart* and *BILD Thüringen*.

[11] The symbols in row two (+, =, -) represent "positive" coverage, "neutral" coverage and "negative" coverage, respectively.

securitisation discourse is more veiled than *BILD*'s; it frames the criminalisation of refugees within broader concerns about the stability of the German labour market, hiding this framing behind supposed concern for the future viability of German business. This framing aligns well with the priorities of its economically liberal readership, who appear to engage with "social" issues principally through their implications for market performance, yet who hold scepticism not altogether different from "everyday" conservatives. Critically, both *BILD* and *Handelsblatt* also advance Islamophobic tropes in their coverage of migration (*e.g.*, using the phrases 'influence of Islam', 'Islamists', *etc.*), explicitly connecting securitisation discourse to Islam and evoking the Islamophobic "threat of Islam" narrative (see Table 4). Accordingly, both *BILD* and *Handelsblatt* contribute directly to narratives co-opted by right-wing extremist groups, fuelling the exclusion of refugee cohorts.

Perhaps most interestingly, the majority of migration coverage in *Der Spiegel* – an ostensibly centre-left source – was negative, regardless of the refugee cohorts being discussed; 57.9% of articles explicitly mentioning Ukrainians and 50% of articles explicitly mentioning Syrians were negative (see Table 3). *Der Spiegel*, like *BILD* and *Handelsblatt*, also employed securitisation discourse, using phrases like 'criminals', 'Islamists' and 'attack perpetrators' to describe refugees (see Table 4). The negative framing of migration found in *Der Spiegel* provides further evidence that anti-migrant sentiment has obtained discursive prominence; anti-migrant sentiment is no longer attributable solely to right-wing and right-wing extremist figures but is now mainstream in centre-left discourse as well. Whether the negative coverage found in *Der Spiegel* – which has become more negative between 2014 and 2024 (see Figure A1.3 in Appendix 1) – represents the wider perceived "rightward" shift in centre-left migration politics critiqued in political science literature (*e.g.,* Del Panta and Guidi, 2022; Kuisma and Ryner, 2012; Polacko, 2022) remains unclear. The connection between *Der Spiegel*'s tonal "rightward" shift and the broader "rightward" shift in centre-left political parties is thus noted here.

While the three "mainstream" outlets – defined by their readership demographics, circulation size and alignment with mainstream political perspectives – were broadly negative in their coverage of migration, engaging heavily with securitisation discourse and more sporadically with integration discourse, *TAZ* notably diverged; two-thirds of its articles mentioning Ukrainians and 90% of its articles mentioning Syrians were positive, and none of its coverage mentioning either cohort was negative (see Table 3). Furthermore, *TAZ* used more humanitarian-coded language to describe migrants, referring to them as 'victims', 'humans' and 'refugees' (rather than "migrants") (see Table 4). Where *TAZ* was "neutral" in its tone toward refugees and migration, it simply described refugees as 'religious' (as compared with negative descriptions of migrants as 'Muslim') or 'immigrants' (as compared with 'illegal' or 'irregular') (see Table 4). It is plausible that *TAZ*'s pro-migrant sentiment can be traced to its unique status as a left-wing alternative news source, as opposed to right-wing sources (*e.g., BILD*) or left-wing mainstream sources (*e.g., Der Spiegel*). The coverage found in *TAZ* broadly echoes the existing sentiment among those loyalists to the political left, particularly among the left-wing urban youth in Berlin, Hamburg and elsewhere. *TAZ*'s engagement with actively anti-racist discourse (*e.g.,* 'No human is illegal', *etc.*) is reminiscent of what one might hear in protests or discussions among its readership. Whereas *Der Spiegel* evinces the discursive prominence of anti-migrant sentiment in Germany, *TAZ* demonstrates that a discursive pro-migrant counter-current actively persists in Germany, even if it does so outside the mainstream.

BILD	*Handelsblatt*	*Der Spiegel*	*TAZ*
• illegal • non-permitted • foreigners • criminal • terror • irregular • perpetrators • suspects • mainly men • hostile to learning • anti-integration • welfare recipients • influence of Islam • economically worse off • bringing less • paid far less	• illegal • overqualified • newcomers • radical • terrorists • uncontrolled • poverty • fled • escape • danger • desperate • distress • fear • labour skills • foreigners • irregular • social welfare • lack of prospects • tolerated • non-permitted • Islamists • attackers	• illegal • overwhelmed • Roma • attack perpetrators • men • overload • foreigners • integration • Islamists • criminals • Muslim	• refugee • humans • racism • religious • racist • immigrants • victim • terrorism

Table 4: Words and phrases used more than once to describe refugee cohorts or associated with descriptions of migrants, translated into English.

Holding the broad discursive trends found in each outlet constant, observing the differences in descriptors used in direct association with Syrian and Ukrainian refugee cohorts reveals the different anti-migrant discursive themes fostered by news media outlets. In articles published by *BILD*, for instance, Syrian refugees are associated with descriptors like 'criminals', 'perpetrators' and 'mainly men'. Meanwhile, Ukrainian refugees are associated with descriptors like 'economically worse-off', 'bringing less', 'paid far less' and 'welfare recipients' (see Table 5). While, in both cases, *BILD* paints a negatively toned picture of the respective refugee cohorts, the language used to do so is securitised for Syrians and economically coded for Ukrainians. This trend is also observed in articles from *Handelsblatt*, where Syrians are associated with descriptors like 'Islamic' and 'outbreaks of violence', while Ukrainians are associated with descriptors like 'social transfer payment recipients' (see Table 5). The articles published by *Der Spiegel* likewise reinforce this trend, with Syrians associated with descriptors like 'attack perpetrators' and 'political Islamists' and Ukrainians associated with descriptors like 'need Hartz-IV payments'[12] and 'committing welfare fraud' (see Table 5). However, *Der Spiegel* also explicitly contrasts the two cohorts along gendered axes, drawing binaries between them. Where Syrian refugees are 'men', Ukrainians are 'women' (see Table 5). As before, *TAZ* was the only outlet whose articles were demonstrably different from those

[12] The colloquially-referred-to "Hartz-IV" payments are welfare benefits received by eligible claimants who are unemployed. Ukrainians are eligible for Hartz-IV under the Temporary Protection Directive.

of the other outlets; *TAZ* articles accurately framed both the Syrian and Ukrainian refugee cohorts as 'refugees', identifying both as fearing 'racism' (see Table 5).

	BILD	***Handelsblatt***	***Der Spiegel***	***TAZ***
Associated with Syrians	• illegal • non-permitted • foreigners • criminals • perpetrators • suspects • irregular • mainly men	• overqualified • Islamic • newcomers • illegal • desperate • outbreaks of violence • foreigners • irregular • non-permitted	• overwhelmed • attack perpetrators • foreigners • unable to integrate • suspects • men • political Islamists • need social transfer payments • Islamic • illegal	• refugees • religion-based racism • protection
Associated with Ukrainians	• illegal • non-permitted • economically worse-off • foreigners • bringing less • paid far less • welfare recipients	• welcomed • foreigners • illegal • irregular • social transfer payment recipients • integral	• women • survivors • illegal • need Hartz-IV payments • able to integrate • well-educated • committing welfare fraud • foreigners	• in fear of racism • regular • refugees

Table 5: Words and phrases associated with Syrian and Ukrainian refugee cohorts, sorted by outlet and translated into English.[13]

The data draw from Table 3 shows that, broadly speaking, news media outlets are unified in their stance on migration. News media outlets, with the minor exception of *Handelsblatt*, do not cover Ukrainian refugees more positively, neutrally or negatively than they cover Syrian refugees. In the case of *Handelsblatt*, coverage of Ukrainian refugees is slightly more negative (46.2%) than coverage of Syrian refugees (35.3%), with the plurality of coverage mentioning Syrian refugees being neutral (41.8%) (see Table 3). However, as data from Tables 4 and 5 show, these anti-migrant discourses are thematically different from one another, with Syrians being portrayed as physical threats and Ukrainians being portrayed as economically exploitative.

Two things are made abundantly clear through this news media discourse analysis: (1) many news media outlets publish, foster and reinforce anti-migrant discourse and (2) the discourses

[13] For a complete list of news media discourse data, see Appendix 1.

used by news media outlets to describe different refugee cohorts are differentiated, even while both are anti-migrant in tone. These findings support and build on the work of Banai and Kreide (2016) and Braun and Nobis (2019) – who critique the securitisation and integration discourses employed against refugees – by showing precisely where and how such discourses are employed and reinforced by news media outlets.

News Media Frameworks and *Generalverdacht*

The framings used by news media outlets, beyond impacting public sentiment and influencing the discourse employed by their respective readerships, have real-world implications for refugee cohorts. Where refugee cohorts in Germany might otherwise find solidarity with one-another in their shared struggles operating within the German system of asylum, refugee cohorts instead feel pitted against one-another. As one of my interlocutors, Carmen Romano, put it:

> 'What happened in 2022 with the Ukrainian crisis was that, actually, a two-class system was built. […] It was absolutely perceived [by Syrians as] "Like, why? Why is it so hard for us?"' (Interview with Romano, 2025).

Here, Romano identifies that Syrians are acutely aware of the disparities in media coverage between themselves and Ukrainians. News media discourse, accordingly, has functioned not only to create a boundary between the native German and the refugee, but also to create boundaries between different refugee cohorts, reinforcing binaries that artificially pit refugee cohorts against one another.

As briefly mentioned in both Chapters 1 and 2, the New Year's Eve attack in Cologne had a significant effect on the public's anti-migrant sentiment. This, too, is reflected in the media discourse analysis; descriptors like 'Muslim criminal gangs' and 'criminal families' appeared between 2016 and 2018 in *BILD*, while descriptors such as 'political violence from the Islamic world' and 'radical Islamic terror' appeared in 2016 in *Handelsblatt*. Clearly, the attack in Cologne catalysed a turn toward securitisation discourse in portrayals of Syrian refugees, who had previously been met with Willkommenskultur throughout the summer and autumn of 2015. Referring to the Constructive Cycle of Migrant Legitimacy, this process represents the link between the "visibilising event" and "media discourse" (see Figure 3); the 2016 Cologne attack, which visibilised Syrian refugees, directly led to negative, securitised portrayals of Syrian refugees in German news media. This is reflected by another of my interlocutors, who stated:

> 'These events [Cologne] triggered…the portrayal – the rather populist and opportunistic exploitation from the media – that you're also referring to, that has, in fact, a significant effect on how the public attitudes changed in these times. [...] Especially the Islamist terrorist attacks in Paris had a main effect, the media would talk especially about migration in cross-reference with Islam [...] And around the Cologne incidents, the media would report especially migration cross-referenced with male, young, violent and…from northern Africa, MENA countries' (Interview with "Interlocutor K", 2025).

"Interlocutor K" thus underscores that in the aftermath of the 2016 Cologne attack, not only did Willkommenskultur wane, but the news media began actively 'cross-referencing' migration with terrorism, associating migration with descriptors like 'male', 'young', 'violent' and 'from MENA countries'. These findings – from my interviews with both "Interlocutor K" and

Carmen Romano, as well as from my news media discourse analysis – support conclusions reached by Vollmer and Karakayali (2018), who documented a discursive shift in the German news media from Willkommenskultur-style empathy to fear-based securitisation discourse in the aftermath of the 2016 Cologne attack. In line with the news media's shift from empathy to fear, the public, likewise, became increasingly suspicious of refugees. The term introduced by another interlocutor, Tatiana Mendonça, Generalverdacht – or the widespread apprehensive sentiment felt against a group of people (*e.g.,* refugees) or organisations (*e.g.*, the European Union) – aptly encapsulates this sentiment; in her interview, Mendonça described Generalverdacht as a pervasive presumption of guilt directed by Germans toward refugees.

Coverage across German news media outlets fuelled and reinforced this climate of Generalverdacht. As news media outlets increasingly employed securitisation discourse against Syrian refugees in the aftermath of the 2016 Cologne attack, readers grew increasingly likely to associate Syrian migration with terrorism and violence. Likewise, as news media outlets employed securitisation discourse throughout 2023 and 2024 against Ukrainian refugees as they received Hartz-IV payments, readers grew increasingly likely to associate Ukrainian migrants with the exploitation of the German welfare state. Importantly, however, as identified in the article by Ulrike Hamann and Serhat Karakayali (2016: 84), a strong counternarrative persisted in Germany even after the gradual decline of Willkommenskultur in 2016, whereby parts of German society stood up against Generalverdacht and racism more broadly, a counternarrative reflected in *TAZ*'s coverage.

Securitisation Discourse and Criminalisation

Having identified that securitisation discourse is commonplace in German news media coverage of migration, it is now pertinent to examine how such discourse contributes to the differential treatment of refugee cohorts. Securitisation discourses both shape public perception of refugee cohorts and reinforce largely symbolic boundaries between them. By associating refugee cohorts with genders (*i.e.*, Syrians as men, Ukrainians as women), criminalising descriptors of refugees become gendered. By associating different types of criminal activity with different refugee cohorts (*i.e.*, Syrians as connected to violent crime, Ukrainians as connected to economic crime), criminalising descriptors are thus also racialised. Along both gendered and racialised dimensions, German news media discursively drives wedges between refugee cohorts, all while criminalising each respective cohort.

The employment of securitisation discourse in German news media outlets, in effect, criminalises refugee cohorts. By criminalisation, I refer to the discursive process by which entire refugee cohorts are presumed to either exhibit or possess the capability to exhibit criminal behaviour, an assumption grounded in recurrent news media portrayals of refugees as particularly criminal. While news media outlets publishing criminalising descriptors like 'illegal' or 'irregular' in connection with refugees might claim that such terminology accurately reflects the legal statuses of refugees they are covering, studies conducted by Mia Wyszynski *et al.* (2020) show that descriptors significantly influence the reception of refugees by host societies. In their study, Wyszynski *et al.* (2020: 607) demonstrate that the descriptor 'refugee' invokes 'dependency-oriented helping intentions' and triggers 'paternalistic stereotypes', whereas other descriptors, like 'economic migrant', increase oppositional attitudes toward aid.

The trend identified by Wyszynski *et al.* (2020) is further reflected by Ulrike Bialas, who, in her interview with me, noted that Muslim migrants, for instance, have been forced into a position whereby they must prove 'that their religious faith and practice is not a danger to the public order', further exemplifying one of the largest results of the employment of

securitisation discourse in the German news media (Banai and Kreide, 2016: 910). Accordingly, German news media outlets that foster associations between criminalising descriptors and specific refugee cohorts – like *BILD*, *Handelsblatt* and to an extent, *Der Spiegel* – play a direct role in shaping the public reception of those refugee cohorts within German society. Referring again to the Constructive Cycle of Migrant Legitimacy, the fostering of associations between criminalising descriptors and specific refugee cohorts is representative of the link from "media discourse" to "migration and integration governance", a connection further explored in Chapters 5 and 6 (see Figure 3).

The anti-refugee discourses identified in *BILD*, *Handelsblatt* and *Der Spiegel* reflect long-established patterns of concerted efforts by German news media to 'link the themes of immigration, crime and security', as Liz Fekete (2009:4), director of the Institute for Race Relations argues (notably prior to the refugee waves beginning in 2014). While securitisation discourses have been pervasive in German news media coverage for decades, so too have patterns of criminalising refugees through accusations of economic exploitation, such as 'milking the system' or engaging in 'welfare cheats' (Fekete, 2009: 5). These anti-migrant discursive traditions in the news media have played a longstanding role in the criminalisation of refugees in distinct ways. Whereas Syrians have been subjected to portrayals of criminalisation through the invocation of physical violence (*e.g.*, coverage broadly linking Syrians to the 2016 Cologne attack), Ukrainians have increasingly been subjected to portrayals of criminalisation through the invocation of economic exploitation (*e.g.*, coverage accusing Ukrainians of taking advantage of the German unemployment welfare scheme). Fekete (2009) shows that both discursive trends form patterns in the German news media landscape; this dissertation confirms that the trends identified by Fekete (2009) remain active and pervasive within German news media discourse.

Thus, securitisation discourse in German news media is not a neutral act of reporting but constitutes a politically charged practice that shapes public sentiment toward migration and, particularly, toward specific refugee cohorts. By portraying Syrian refugees through associations with physically violent crime and Ukrainian refugees through allegations of economic exploitation, mainstream outlets like *BILD*, *Handelsblatt*, and *Der Spiegel* actively delineate which refugees are permitted to belong, and on what terms. These representations are both gendered and racialised, creating a conditional inclusion where support for refugee cohorts can be withdrawn at any time as perception fluctuates. In doing so, German news media outlets sustain a shifting hierarchy of exclusion, in which refugee cohorts are strategically pitted against one another, and criminalisation is utilised to legitimise public anti-migrant sentiment.

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In sum, this chapter's news media discourse analysis has revealed: (1) that mainstream news media outlets widely publish anti-migrant articles, fostering and reinforcing anti-migrant sentiment (see Table 3); (2) that anti-migrant news media discourses vary in theme between different refugee cohorts, with Syrians being portrayed as physical threats and Ukrainians as economically exploitative (see Table 4; Table 5); (3) that anti-migrant news media coverage is, in most cases, elaborated through the use of securitisation and integration discourses, which are both gendered and racialised and that pit refugee cohorts against one another; (4) that anti-migrant news media coverage fuels and reinforces a climate of Generalverdacht toward refugees in Germany and (5) that a strong counternarrative, standing firm against racism and anti-migrant sentiment, persists in Germany, reflected in this analysis by *TAZ*'s coverage.

This chapter's news media discourse analysis also confirms that portions of the Constructive Cycle of Migrant Legitimacy hold true for both Syrian and Ukrainian refugees (see Figure 3). Whereas the 2016 Cologne attack catalysed a shift from Willkommenskultur-era public discourse to securitisation discourse targeting Syrian refugees, specifically, leading to Generalverdacht, the reception of Hartz-IV payments by Ukrainian refugees between 2023 and 2024 also catalysed a shift from solidaristic public discourse to securitisation discourse targeting Ukrainian refugees, leading also to Generalverdacht. Further chapters will continue exploring other links along the Constructive Cycle of Migrant Legitimacy, especially links between migration governance regimes and the calcification of societal anti-migrant sentiment.

5. The Role of Aesthetics in Anti-Migrant Sentiment

Refugee reception and legitimacy in Germany is structured in part by aesthetic and cultural judgements which have the effect of obscuring the minimal differences between migrants and non-migrants and reinforcing and exacerbating anti-migrant sentiment. This chapter examines how aesthetic proximity functions as a reinforcing, exacerbating and shaping factor in German migrant admission and governance. It draws on quantitative data and insights from interlocutors, arguing that aesthetic proximity is not a static marker of acceptance, but is a framework for understanding the differential ways by which refugee cohorts are excluded in Germany. Tracing the experiences of Ukrainian and Syrian refugees, this section demonstrates how proximity and distance serve as the visual scaffolding upon which refugees are racialised, explaining one part of the broader mosaic of refugee exclusion in Germany.

Aesthetic Proximity

Visual and affective cues reinforce admission discourses employed by Germans upon refugees' arrival, exacerbate anti-migrant sentiment in the aftermath of a visibilising event and shape migration and integration governance through economic judgements (see Figure 3). This reinforcement and exacerbation is best explored through the lens of aesthetic proximity. In the German context, aesthetic proximity refers to the degree to which refugees are aesthetically perceived as similar to the German majority. This proximity can be based on clothing, appearance, language, symbols and presentation. Thus, aesthetic proximity in the German context is not simply about "looking" German (in ethnic terms) but is rather about the proximity of one's identity to the image of a modern, liberal 21st-century German[14].

In my discussion with Steven Vertovec, one of my interlocutors, the point was raised that many Ukrainian refugees arrived with pets and with a European education. Many Ukrainians were thus aesthetically judged as middle-class; their fashion and consumption patterns aligned with German tastes. Accordingly, Vertovec observed that Ukrainians were aesthetically proximal to Germans, which initially reinforced the admission discourses of solidarity applied to Ukrainians. "Interlocutor B" similarly noted that Ukrainians were largely perceived as 'other Europeans', suggesting that, if not heard speaking, they might be mistaken for 'Polish or Hungarian' citizens. Yet rather than shielding Ukrainian refugees from exclusion long-term, their aesthetic proximity to Germans has simply channelled discursive and institutional expressions of anti-migrant sentiment along new lines. Precisely because Ukrainians are perceived as aesthetically similar to Germans, they have become targets of resentment couched in economic and moral terms in the aftermath of widespread perceptions that they are exploiting the German welfare system through the reception, for example, of Hartz-IV payments. Whereas Ukrainians' aesthetic proximity bolstered solidarity discourses prior to the visibilising event described above, in its aftermath, their aesthetic proximity exacerbated and reinforced anti-migrant sentiment found in news media discourse. Syrian refugees, too, have been subjected to this pattern. Being perceived as aesthetically "non-European" and "war refugees", dominant humanitarian admission discourses were reinforced by Syrians' aesthetic distance from Germans. Yet, in the aftermath of their visibilising event – the 2016 Cologne attack – their aesthetic distance exacerbated anti-migrant sentiments found in news media discourse, which itself attacked Syrians' (assumed) religious affiliations, ethnicities and levels of threat.

In some cases, aesthetic proximity functions by presuming refugees' identities. According to Ulrike Bialas, another interlocutor of mine, in other cases, refugees' *actual* aesthetic proximity,

[14] For more on the impact of aesthetic proximity on migration, see Weber and Saarela (2023).

rather than their assumed aesthetic proximity, bears upon their participation in and exclusion from the German bureaucratic system. For instance, Bialas mentioned how the complicated German bureaucratic system – with its focus on neat administrative categories – is illegible for those whose bureaucracies of origin do not possess the same organisational categories, especially for those refugees who do not fit predefined administrative expectations set by German bureaucratic institutions. For these refugees, their aesthetic distance actively bears upon their administrative exclusion throughout their journey through the German system.

Already playing a role in the reinforcement of admission discourse and exacerbation of anti-migrant news media discourse, aesthetic judgements also shape migration and integration governance. As "Interlocutor K" said:

> 'Germany [...] has now moved away a lot from the humanitarian discourse [and] towards more neoliberal, capitalist-informed discourses on deservingness, [which are also aesthetically informed.] Economic narratives always also play a role' (Interview with "Interlocutor K", 2025).

Insofar, then, as aesthetic judgements shape images of refugees' economic deservingness and viability, respectively, aesthetic proximity plays a role in migration and integration governance (see Figure 3). Migrants who are aesthetically distant from the "modern German", through their clothing, language or public presentation (*e.g.,* Syrian refugees), are less readily interpreted by the German regime of migration and integration governance as economically "viable", leading to their exclusion. In other cases, migrants who are aesthetically proximal and, thus, are judged as economically "non-deserving" of welfare (*e.g.*, Ukrainian refugees), are more likely to be excluded from German welfare regimes throughout their process of migration and integration. Aesthetic proximity thus operates as a filtering mechanism in the 'neoliberal' German economy of migration, compounding and sustaining refugee exclusion.

Acknowledging the role that perceptions of aesthetic proximity play in the inclusion and exclusion of refugees, especially as Germany begins to focus its official standards of inclusion on economic viability and deservingness narratives, it is important to investigate the proximity of refugees along such lines. Accordingly, refugees' language skills, employment and criminality become important comparison points by which one can definitively show that refugees "belong" in Germany (as they are economically viable for the state), even if they are aesthetically distant. Herbert Brücker *et al.* (2016: 541-552) emphasise this point, showing that refugees in Germany are eager and willing to work and that refugees participate extensively in language acquisition programmes. My quantitative findings – drawn from hypothesis tests run on data from the Socio-Economic Panel (DIW Berlin, 2025) – support the notion that refugee cohorts, be they Ukrainian or Syrian, are not statistically different from one another in their capacity to learn German, a key indicator of one's economic viability in Germany (see Figure 4). Though not statistically different from one another, the hypothesis tests run on data from the Socio-Economic Panel demonstrate that, across the categories of class grades and writing and speaking ability in German, Syrian refugee youth slightly outperform Ukrainian refugee youth (see Figure 4; DIW Berlin, 2025).

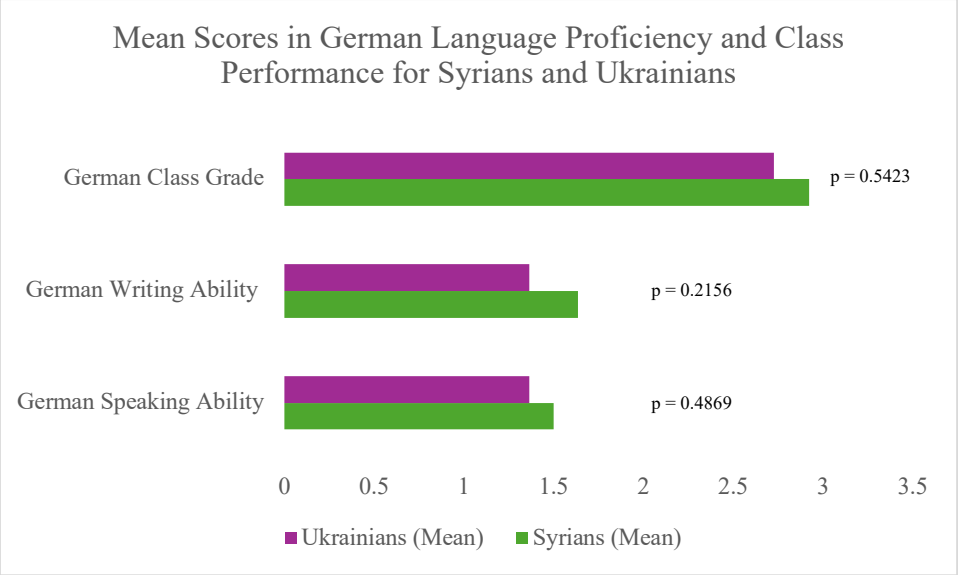

Figure 4: Comparative German speaking ability, writing ability and class grades of Syrian and Ukrainian refugee youth (DIW Berlin, 2025).

In sum, aesthetic proximity offers another lens through which one can understand the differentiated reception of refugee cohorts in Germany. Referring to the Constructive Cycle of Migrant Legitimacy (see Figure 3), aesthetic proximity reinforces admission discourses, exacerbates anti-migrant news media discourses and shapes judgements of economic deservingness, impacting migration and integration governance. Refugees, like Ukrainians, who have been visually perceived as proximal to Germans have encountered exclusion along notions of economic non-deservingness. Other refugees, like Syrians, who have been visually perceived as distant from Germans have encountered exclusion along notions of economic non-viability. Yet, both proximal and distant refugees have experienced anti-migrant exclusion in Germany.

Who Belongs? Racialisation and Cultural Difference

Distinct from, yet connected with, aesthetic proximity, assumptions about cultural difference and identity also bear upon the institutional regimes of migration and integration governance. Many of the assumptions bound to cultural markers and identity-based categories originate in news media discourse, particularly discourses targeting specific identity-based groups, like Muslims ("political Islamists"), for example (see Table 5). This is made apparent in analysing the treatment of refugees perceived to be Muslim in Germany, whose exclusion is mediated not just by phenotypic evaluations (*e.g.,* skin colour), but also by perceived fixity of culture, religion and values.

The nature of Generalverdacht renders refugees perceived to be Muslim hyper-visible and morally suspect (along largely securitised lines), in the aftermath of a visibilising event, positioning them as incompatible with German civic identity. This manifests in social attitudes and bureaucratic procedures that demand legibility on the part of refugees while denying it in practice. Worn religious symbols, spoken and written language and unfamiliar cultural norms are read as markers of societal deviance from the (imagined) German norm. Belonging is thus dictated, in part, by perceived cultural and aesthetic proximity, which structures the hierarchies through which refugees are excluded. One of my interlocutors, a prominent migration scholar and the director of the Max Planck Institute Steven Vertovec, said:

> ‘We still think of race in terms of colour or phenotype, but racialisation happens when people see religion or culture as fixed, unchangeable traits. […] It’s not necessarily skin colour – cultural differences can be racialised too’ (Interview with Vertovec, 2025).

Here, Vertovec emphasises that racialisation can occur in conjunction with one’s culture, religion, class and language. Vertovec observes that racialisation is often wrongly assumed to be solely about skin colour; in fact, societies frequently associate groups with race through cultural and social categories. One’s religion, for example, can mark someone as belonging to a racial group as strongly as one’s skin colour. In the German context, the subject of the racialisation identified by Vertovec is refugees.

The racialisation of refugees in Germany is closely tethered to the Generalverdacht held by the native German population and is filtered through news media discourse. For instance, in the words of representative Tatiana Mendonça from the Migrationsbeirat München:

> ‘I think some people are really afraid and most people are just racist because they can use [terrorist attacks] to justify [their racism]. […] It’s always this Generalverdacht’ (Interview with Mendonça, 2025).

Mendonça refers to the concept of Generalverdacht to explain the racism exhibited toward refugees in Germany: Generalverdacht, however, is not solely phenotypic, but also emerges from perceptions of others’ clothing, worn religious symbols, presentation and gender. Generalverdacht, also, is filtered through the discourses employed by the news media; Generalverdacht toward Syrian refugees is exhibited along notions of physical (in)security, whereas Generalverdacht toward Ukrainian refugees is exhibited along notions of (un)deservingness. Accordingly, while both refugee cohorts have been racialised in Germany, their racialisation has occurred along different paths, with Syrians filtered through (supposed) religious identity and Ukrainians filtered through (supposed) material welfare.

Empirically substantiating the racialisation of Syrian refugees in Germany, scholarship has proven that a quantifiable public preference for non-Muslim refugees exists in Germany (Bansak *et al.,* 2016: 219). In the case of Ukrainian refugees in Germany, researchers have shown, too, that refugees are disadvantaged in Germany when they are perceived to be unemployed and unskilled (Bansak *et al.*, 2016: 219). Perception, rather than self-identification, matters in both cases; it is native Germans’ ‘sociotropic evaluations of’ refugees’ religiosity and economic viability that informs their disposition towards refugees (Bansak *et al.*, 2016: 218). Refugees are thus racialised via their identities, leading to systemic disadvantages.

As mentioned above, refugees arriving in Germany find the regime of migration and integration governance difficult to understand, particularly through the rigid administrative categories imposed on refugees. This illegibility leads directly to poor integration outcomes, indirect exclusion and negative societal perceptions of migrants. In my interview with Ulrike Bialas, a researcher from the Max Planck Institute, she said:

> ‘Germany has very rigid ideas about how certain categories work – like age or nationality – that turn out to be quite complicated in practice. And, I mean, that leads to illegibility on the part of migrants’ (Interview with Bialas, 2025).

Bialas suggests that the German state presumes administrative categories, such as age, nationality or gender, to be fixed and immutable. However, as she later elaborates in our interview, such categories are socially constructed and culturally contingent, which can produce dissonance for refugees unfamiliar with German conventions. For example, whereas the convention of age in the European Union considers adults to be those over 18 years old, this is not true for much of the global south, where one's status as an adult is sometimes tied to one's marital status. Thus, a category assumed to be administratively simple (*e.g.*, whether one is a child or an adult) becomes illegible for refugees who do not possess the same cultural context as those who have created the administrative categories present in migration and integration governance regimes. This is one way in which refugees are systemically disadvantaged in the web of German institutions. Yet rather than adapting to these realities, German bureaucratic regimes continue to apply illegible categories rigidly. In this absence of reform, and in conjunction with the presence of societal Generalverdacht toward refugees, cultural suspicion has become embedded in the administrative categories and bureaucratic rationality of Germany.

Taken together, the empirical evidence from Bansak *et al.* (2016) and insights from my interlocutors demonstrates that refugees face both overt and latent displays of racialisation in Germany. The process of racialisation unfolds through assumptions guided by cultural difference, Generalverdacht toward refugees and administrative exclusion. As my interlocutors note, the notion of "deservingness" has become entangled with these perceptions, reinforcing hierarchies of belonging that embed anti-migrant discourse into institutional logics. In doing so, German institutions both mirror public prejudices and reproduce these biases through policy design and implementation. The racialisation of refugee groups is thus not a by-product of cultural misunderstanding but is a structural logic within contemporary German migration governance.

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Aesthetic cues exacerbate media discourses and become embedded in and shape institutional logics within the German regime of migration and integration governance. Narratives stemming from the news media prime aesthetic frameworks that bureaucracies subsequently operationalise through integration governance, legal categorisations and eligibility for social programmes. The Constructive Cycle of Migrant Legitimacy demonstrates that both aesthetic proximity and cultural difference can be mobilised to exclude, albeit via different logics (see Figure 3). Whereas Ukrainians are cast as economically undeserving, Syrians are framed as culturally unfit. This chapter has shown that such framings are reflective of prejudice and constitute a pipeline through which media discourse becomes institutional understanding. The next chapter shifts focus from discursive representation to administrative articulation, exploring how institutional actors reify these logics in migration and integration governance regimes, capturing how refugee exclusion is made routine within the very mechanisms tasked with integrating refugees.

6. Institutionalising Belonging in German Migration Governance

In Germany, the institutional governance of migration and integration functions as an arbiter of belonging. Far from being neutral, bureaucratic systems translate discursive frames originating in news media discourse into concrete administrative practice. This chapter investigates how legal categorisation, judgements of refugees' "deservingness" and moral exclusion are operationalised through exclusionary migration and integration governance regimes. This chapter examines how racial, ethnic, religious and gendered assumptions about refugees are rendered actionable through administrative practice. It shows how institutions transform media discourse into concrete barriers to rights and resources, producing exclusionary results while maintaining a veneer of "equality". Ultimately, this chapter argues that Germany's migration and integration governance regimes actively shape the terms of national belonging and refugee legitimacy.

Institutional Operationalisation of Anti-Migrant Discourse

Where aesthetic judgements and news media discourse shape social responses to and associations with refugees, legal categorisation renders such discourses bureaucratically actionable. German migration and integration governance is reinforced by broader discourses about who is presumed to "belong" and in turn reinforces the societal calcification of anti-migrant sentiment. Accordingly, the differentiated migration and integration governance regimes applied to Syrian and Ukrainian refugees echo those discourses and reinforce the terms along which German society expresses anti-migration sentiment. By adapting refugees' access to rights, ranging from freedom of movement to eligibility for welfare benefits, German institutions are responding to the logics dominating news media coverage. These formalised legal regimes do not simply reflect social prejudices, they institutionalise them.

In my interview with Marie Walter-Franke, a researcher with the Expert Council for Integration and Migration (SVR), she noted the drastically different regimes of migration and integration governance faced by Syrian and Ukrainian refugees in Germany. Specifically, she noted how Ukrainian refugees have not been subjected to the same movement and employment restrictions as Syrian refugees have been. Yet, the differentiated regimes of governance observed by Walter-Franke reflect and reproduce securitised logics already present in public discourse. As "violent Islamist perpetrators", Syrians were subjected to the Residenzpflicht and restricted from employment by the German state (see Table 5). As Ukrainians were not painted as violent threats to the German nation, these same restrictions never manifested for them. Instead, being depicted as "welfare recipients", Ukrainian refugees are having their initial welfare allowances restricted by the newly formed German government, as promised by Friedrich Merz[15] during his campaign (see Table 5; Dell'Anna *et al.*, 2025).

The application of the Residenzpflicht – the restriction of movement imposed in Germany at threat of fine – on Syrian refugees provides another illustration of bureaucratic exclusion. Unlike systems that exist in the rest of European migration governance, Germany 'imposes a Residenzpflicht' on all who enter on asylum claims (Schuster, 2003: 248; Asylgesetz 1992 §56, §85). Those who 'breach' the regulations applied to them by the Residenzpflicht – most often, asylum seekers who are not permitted to work in Germany – may be fined (Schuster, 2003: 248; Asylgesetz 1992 §56, §85). Liza Schuster (2003: 248) examines a case study in the German state of Thüringen, where asylum-seekers were bound by the Residenzpflicht which did not allow them to leave their designated zone of movement to utilise the region's only public telephone, a crucial point of access in the pre-mobile phone era. As these asylum-seekers

[15] Friedrich Merz is the current leader of the CDU and the new Chancellor of Germany.

regularly breached their Residenzpflicht, the 'opportunity for the local police…to intimidate the asylum-seekers at will' was created (Schuster, 2003: 248). In short, by imposing the Residenzpflicht, with its 'abundant opportunities for abuse', on Syrian refugees, who are deemed as "violent Islamist threats", the regime of migration and integration governance is actively operationalising securitised logics originating in the news media, further reinforcing the Constructive Cycle of Migrant Legitimacy (see Table 5; see Figure 3; Jesse, 2002; Igbinoba, 2002; Classen, 2002; Hügel 2002, cited in Schuster, 2003: 248). Though Ukrainian refugees were not subjected to the same restrictions of movement and employment as Syrian refugees, neither were they immunised from anti-migrant governance. In the news media discourse, this has been evinced by the coverage of Ukrainians as "welfare recipients" and in the migration and integration governance regime, by the restrictions placed upon their entitlements to welfare schemes.

Contrasting with Walter-Franke's earlier account of differentialised migration governance regimes, Jan Schneider, another researcher with the SVR, remarked:

> 'Subconscious differentialisation exists, yes. But the state tries to apply [migration governance] equally' (Interview with Schneider, 2025).

While affirming the formal neutrality of migration governance processes, Schneider simultaneously concedes that bureaucratic actors operate with subconscious biases. This indifference, whereby embedded differentialisation is ignored in favour of the notion of "official" equality, mirrors the broader German institutional logics, which are shaped by prevailing discursive frameworks. The German state's "equal" application of migration governance is situated within and shaped by differential anti-migrant logics.

Further reinforcing the notion that the German state functions, in part, as an anti-migrant bulwark, furthering racism against refugees regardless of their origin, is the fact that members of all refugee cohorts are arrested and convicted at significantly higher rates than their German counterparts, even when arrests and convictions regarding breaches of migration law are excluded (see Table 6; Bundeskriminalamt, 2024; Destatis, 2025c). This divergence is likely explained by several mechanisms. For those refugees who are bound by work restrictions and the Residenzpflicht, the need to provide for basic needs may outweigh legal consequences. For others, racism itself, especially where connected with Generalverdacht and securitisation discourses around economic crime, may lead to higher rates of arrest and conviction. In either case, the fact that the German justice system routinely arrests and convicts refugees at a much higher rate than Germans indicates that anti-migrant sentiment is reproduced within German institutions. This data also points to the opportunity for migration and integration governance regimes to lead to the ossification of anti-migrant sentiment in the wider society; anti-migrant institutional actors, like the right-wing extremist AfD warp and misinterpret data like that found in Table 6, asserting that refugees, by their very nature, are more criminal than "native" Germans, effectively calcifying anti-migrant sentiment in wider German society (see Figure 3).

Hypothesis	Cohort	X^2	p-value	Conclusion
Arrest rate	All migrant cohorts	426809	2.20E-16	Strong association
Conviction rate	All migrant cohorts	9211.7	2.20E-16	Strong association

Table 6: Table displaying the results of the chi-squared tests on the predictive effect of one's background as a refugee on arrest and conviction rate indicators (Bundeskriminalamt, 2024; Destatis, 2025c).

The bureaucratic exclusion identified by my interlocutors and Drewski and Gerhards (2024b) is a symptom of the broader securitisation logics operationalised by German institutions of migration and integration governance against refugees. Fekete (2009: 14) identifies as much insofar as she explains how the rise of the German 'national security prison complex' parallels a system of migration governance that treats 'whole categories of people…as constituting risk'. These broad securitisation logics both lead directly to the development of a prison industrial complex that directly targets refugees, justified by national security concerns and indirectly to everyday bureaucratic exclusion driven by operationalised securitisation logics. Fekete (2009: 15) confirms this notion, noting that only in a society dominated by anti-migrant internalisations could the bureaucratic exclusion of refugee cohorts be justified.

Reflecting the broader societal ossification of anti-migrant sentiment, right-wing extremist parties like the AfD have succeeded in seizing on societal discontent with migration (see Figure 3; The Federal Returning Officer, 2025). These developments underscore that differential inclusion is not a shield from exclusion, but a conscious operationalisation of already-dominant discourse. In sum, the legal categorisations and bureaucratic frameworks governing migration in Germany encode an understanding of belonging that reflects and reinforces securitised logics from the news media.

Integration and "Deservingness"

Throughout their stay in Germany, be it short-term, long-term or permanent, migrants are continually imagined as fitting into "good versus bad" binaries. These imaginaries are developed through migrants' processes of integration. After admission and relocation to Germany, refugees are encouraged to integrate into the German economy and society, and in the process, are cast as either "assimilable" or "not assimilable", "deserving" or "undeserving", "good" or "bad". Gradually, German migration and integration governance institutions – as noted by "Interlocutor K" – have employed so-called "meritocratic" narratives of integration, based in part around judgements of refugees' economic "deservingness" and "viability", as stated in Chapter 5. Despite the contemporary framing of integration as a meritocratic process, institutional constraints, like the Residenzpflicht, employment restrictions and welfare restrictions, preclude many refugees from demonstrating the very merit demanded of them. As articulated by another interlocutor of mine:

> 'If you're not allowed to work and you can't leave your residential zone, or if you have limited access to social benefits, you become visible, idle, suspicious' (Interview with "Interlocutor B" (paraphrased), 2025).

"Interlocutor B" articulated one of the mechanisms of heightened criminalisation mentioned previously, that binding refugees by the Residenzpflicht provides a pipeline directly into the German justice system. For those forbidden from leaving their area of residence, any deviation,

even if necessary (see Fekete, 2003) makes one a criminal. Other mechanism previously mentioned was work restrictions; for those refugee cohorts forbidden from working or limited in their ability to receive social benefits, but still requiring resources to meet basic necessities, suspicion was fostered among native Germans that refugees were "pilfering" the welfare system.

Although German institutions claim to evaluate integration through meritocratic criteria, Ukrainian refugees, despite being held up as a model of successful integration, challenge this logic in practice. Quantitative data, taken from chi-squared tests run on data from the European Social Survey, reveals a significant association between Ukrainian refugees and unemployment, whereas no such association exists for Syrian refugees, even as Ukrainian refugees' access to employment has not been restricted to the degree that Syrian refugees' access has (see Table 7; Norwegian Agency for Shared Services in Education and Research, 2025). This is not a critique of Ukrainian refugees themselves, many of whom initially anticipated a swift return to Ukraine and therefore delayed seeking long-term employment, but of the institutional logic that selectively offers rights to migrants, while maintaining the veneer of systemic equality. By allowing Ukrainian refugees to become employed, all while preventing them from attaining the resources and aid to become employed through restrictions on social benefits, discourses of economic "non-deservingness" are operationalised and confirmed by institutions of migration and integration governance, eroding public solidarity with migrants and calcifying public anti-migrant sentiments.

Hypothesis	Cohort	X^2	p-value	Conclusion
Full-time occupation (see caption)	Syrian	0.54747	0.4593	No association
	Ukrainian	4.4049	0.03583	Moderate association
Unemployment	Syrian	2.6624	0.1027	Weak or incomplete association
	Ukrainian	8.0888	0.004454	Strong association

Table 7: Table displaying the results of the chi-squared tests on the predictive effect of one's refugee background (Syrian or Ukrainian) on doing a full-time occupation (either student or employment) and unemployment rates (Norwegian Agency for Shared Services in Education and Research, 2025).

In addition to the meritocratic frameworks employed by German institutions, the state measures integration through participation and success in mandatory integration courses. Integration courses are meant to extend "belonging" to refugee cohorts equally by offering refugees education on democratic norms, the German language and "German values". Yet, even after Syrian refugees have completed these integration courses, they are excluded from the national community through Generalverdacht and calcified presumptions of their "violence" and "radicalism", implying that integration courses are performative in nature.

Taking "Interlocutor K's" assertion that the integration framework employed by German institutions is gradually becoming 'neoliberal', focused on economic deservingness, it becomes necessary to interrogate how the neoliberal integration framework functions in practice. According to Holzberg *et al.* (2018: 547), 'deservingness operates as a mode of bordering' between the refugee "outsider" and the German "insider". Their work echoes and underpins this bureaucratic critique, emphasising that refugees are excluded from belonging and that they must 'prove that they are worthy of protection' (Holzberg *et al.*, 2018: 547). German integration governance operates less as an extension of belonging (as evinced by the failure of Germans to

rescind Generalverdacht against Syrians after they have completed integration courses) and more as an evaluative apparatus, regardless of the legal status of its subjects (*e.g.*, asylum-seekers). By evaluating and subsequently excluding refugees, German integration frameworks continue in their longstanding pattern of framing the nation 'as a racially and ethnically homogenous entity that erects clear boundaries of belonging' (Holzberg *et al.*, 2018: 547). While neoliberal logics claim merit-based neutrality, economic "deservingness" functions as an excluding apparatus precisely because it renders structural barriers invisible, shifting responsibility for economic wellbeing onto the refugee themselves.

Taken together, the insights from my interlocutors, quantitative data and theoretical literature articulate that refugee cohorts, regardless of origin, are presumed not to "belong" in Germany. Neoliberal frameworks of economic "deservingness" break down initial humanitarian admission discourses, which recognised the economic and social woes facing refugees upon arrival; they are utilised to cast migrants as "bad" in light of their presumed economic need, fuelling refugee exclusion and calcifying societal anti-migrant sentiment.

Moral Exclusion and Reflecting on the Past

Vergangenheitsbewältigung, or historical memory tied to Germany's national socialist (Nazi) regime, plays a significant role in shaping native Germans' political attitudes, especially where those attitudes are intersectional with migration. Although Germany has grappled seriously with its Nazi past, Germans are not immune to expressions of anti-migrant racism. As previously articulated, the exclusion of refugee cohorts is partially driven by presumptions of religion. Additionally, refugee groups' exclusion is also driven by ethnic perceptions, even targeting other "white" refugees (*e.g.,* eastern Europeans). This is distinguishable in the reception faced by refugees from the Balkan Peninsula in the 1990s, echoing historical logics which targeted "Slavs" and more recently in the gradually increasing exclusion of Ukrainian refugees. German gender biases also play a role in the moral exclusion of refugees. Accordingly, though German politics are consistently impacted by historical memories of the national socialist regime, racism, ethnic tension and gender biases still plague German understandings of belonging.

Focusing on the exclusion of Muslim refugees, Özyürek (2023) details how, even post-arrival and post-integration, Muslim refugees become 'subcontractors' of Holocaust guilt. Especially in the aftermath of the 7 October 2023 attack on Israel, Muslim refugees in Germany – already subjected to violence- and threat-related Generalverdacht – have been additionally subjected to presumptions of antisemitism (Özyürek, 2023). Native Germans, citing the burden of their history, rally strongly against presumed antisemitism, placing the burden of their past onto Muslim refugees. Yet, as articulated previously, Germans simultaneously employ exclusionary logics from the very history they rally against. This trend is confirmed by Partridge (2010), who asserts that Muslims are excluded from 'moral belonging' in Germany via accusations of widespread antisemitism. The exclusion of (perceived) Muslims justified by accusations of antisemitism is not novel in Germany, but rather, traces back to institutional debates at the turn of the 21st century, wherein institutions were incredibly sceptical about the arrival of refugees from MENA countries and about Turkish accession to the EU (Bunzl, 2005).

The use of logics against perceived Muslims that echo those employed by the national socialist regime against the German Jewish population suggests that Germany's post-war reckoning, while extensive in certain areas, has not entailed a sustained confrontation with structural racism and its continuities. This is confirmed by Carmen Romano, who said:

> ‘The narrative has been more: we’re not Nazis anymore. […] [But] that hasn’t included reflecting on racism [or] the structural aspects of it’ (Interview with Romano, 2025).

Romano further discusses the failure of Germany to reflect on structural racism, confirming the notion that religious groups – particularly Muslims – have been racialised in Germany, continuing:

> ‘[Native Germans] said it’s against Muslims and *muslimgelesense Menschen*.[16] […] People, independent of what their religion actually is, […] have been discriminated against as…Muslim[s]’ (Interview with Romano, 2025).

Given the persistent evidence that native Germans discriminate against refugees based in part on their perceptions of one’s religion, the question of religiosity becomes relevant. Namely, is there a statistical difference in the self-identified religiosity between refugees from Syria and refugees from Ukraine or Germans? As my quantitative analysis of data from the European Social Survey confirms (see Table 8), the relationship between religiosity and one’s refugee background is weak or incomplete (Norwegian Agency for Shared Services in Education and Research, 2025).

Hypothesis	Intercept	Estimate (Syrian)	Estimate (Ukrainian)	Estimate (German)	p-value	R^2 (adjusted)	Conclusion
Religiosity (scale of 0-10, self-reported)	5.0087	6.04706	4.75269	2.76471	0.000279	0.005003	Weak or incomplete statistical relationship

Table 8: Table displaying the results of the ordinary least squares regression models on the predictive effect of one’s refugee background (Syrian, Ukrainian, or none/native German) on one’s religiosity (Norwegian Agency for Shared Services in Education and Research, 2025).

The quantitative results suggest that one’s refugee background explains almost none of the variance in self-reported religiosity (see Table 8); the stereotype, then, of the “hyper-religious” Syrian refugee is empirically unfounded. This analysis confirms the claim made throughout this work: Syrian refugees, who are not “more religious” than native Germans in a statistically significant way, are ascribed the role of the “radical”, the “Islamist” and the “criminal”, to use a few examples from news media articles describing Syrians (see Table 5). These ascriptions, made initially by discourse from the news media in their coverage of a visibilising event, are then operationalised by migration and integration governance regimes.

As previously articulated, institutionalised anti-migrant racism, supported by news media discourse and exemplified by administrative categories, bureaucratic practices, differential applications of protective status, ever-changing integration frameworks, employment restrictions and free movement restrictions – to name a few examples – is widespread in Germany. Yet, the exclusion of migrants in Germany is not only shaped by perceptions of religion and ethnicity; it is also structured by gendered expectations of vulnerability and threat. In their interview with me, “Interlocutor K” said:

[16] The translation of *muslimgelesene Menschen* in English is ‘people perceived to be Muslim’.

> ‘[Public empathy] is also a very gendered thing. […] How…deservingness of protection is construed, it’s always…intersecting [with gender]’ (Interview with “Interlocutor K”, 2025).

The gendered dimension of refugee exclusion plays a significant role in the reception of Ukrainian migrants since 2022. Because of exit restrictions placed on men in the beginning of the war between Russia and Ukraine, many of the first Ukrainian refugees to arrive in Germany were women and children. In response, Ukrainian refugees – even after men began to arrive – were afforded significant public empathy by German public and institutions alike. Echoing the “humanitarian” framework of migrant admission, “Interlocutor K” articulates how (initial) public empathy and discourse has been significantly shaped by gender biases.

Refugee exclusion in Germany is thus a blend of religious, ethnic and gender-based discrimination. This intersectional exclusion is exemplified by the aforementioned 2016 Cologne attack, which coincided with a significant drop in public empathy for Syrian refugees. The perpetrators of the 2016 Cologne attack were framed by news media outlets as Arab, Muslim and Middle Eastern men – ethnically and religiously “different” and of a “threatening” gender.

The exclusion of refugees along intersectional categories of race, religion, ethnicity and gender is not a coincidence, nor is it novel. This exclusion is a continuation of German historical patterns and a consequence of constructing refugee legitimacy on perceptions of refugees’ religious, ethnic, racial and gender identities. The interplay of memory, religion, ethnicity and gender constitutes a complex web of moral exclusion, emerging from historical categories that continue to shape institutional responses. German migration governance reflects deeper symbolic struggles over who is seen as “within” the moral community of the nation.

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As this chapter has shown, assumptions of race, religion, ethnicity and gender are deeply embedded in the institutional architecture of migration and integration governance in Germany. The differential treatment of refugee cohorts during the process of integration is contingent on the discourses used to describe each cohort, with Syrians being institutionally treated as threats and Ukrainians as economic burdens. In doing so, the state reinforces frameworks of refugee legitimacy, rendering them actionable through policy. The aesthetic and moral framings of “deservingness” articulated in Chapter 5 are deployed bureaucratically, influencing refugees’ access to social support, economic mobility, employment and recognition. Integration, too, functions less as an invitation into national belonging than as an apparatus of evaluation and exclusion.

The bureaucratic exclusion of refugees in Germany is not novel but rather echoes historical structures and patterns of migrant exclusion. Though Germany has formally reckoned with the atrocities of its 20th-century history, the persistence of exclusionary logics reveals the limits of remembrance. By demonstrating how institutional frameworks mediate and magnify discursive framings, this chapter bridges media discourse with migration and integration governance, as articulated in the Constructive Cycle of Migrant Legitimacy (see Figure 3). It confirms that the German systematises media discourses, sustaining the exclusion of refugees.

7. Conclusion

This dissertation aimed to address several questions stemming from observations of the 21st-century refugee crises that Germany has faced. The first of these questions asked how one can conceptualise the pattern of migration politics in Germany. The theoretical framework introduced in Chapter 2, the Constructive Cycle of Migrant Legitimacy (see Figure 3), attempts to explain the recurrent pattern of migration politics in Germany, with Chapters 4, 5 and 6 mapping the experiences of Syrian and Ukrainian refugees in Germany based on the cycle. Chapter 4, 'Media Discourse and Anti-Migrant Narratives', analysed news media discourses between 2014 and 2024 to evaluate how the news media constructs anti-migrant narratives in the aftermath of visibilising events. It also found that, with the exception of *TAZ*, German news media organisations publish and foster anti-migrant sentiments, regardless of their purported political stances (*e.g.*, left-wing, liberal, right-wing, *et cetera*). Chapter 5, 'The Role of Aesthetics in Anti-Migrant Sentiment', investigated the impact of aesthetics and cultural difference on the themes of the discourses used by the news media and the discourses used upon the admission of refugees, showing how both aesthetically proximal and distant refugees are disadvantaged in the regime of German migration governance. Chapter 6, 'Institutionalising Belonging in German Migration Governance', showed how news media discourses are operationalised by German migration and integration governance regimes, simultaneously investigating the roles of structural racism and intersectional refugee identities to explain how these regimes of migration and integration governance actively exclude refugees from belonging.

The second question this dissertation asked is how the news media impacts the pattern of German migration governance. This was addressed by the analyses in Chapter 4, which began with a discourse analysis that revealed the anti-migrant language utilised and published by different news media organisations in Germany before shifting into more contextual analyses of securitisation discourses employed by the same news media organisations. Chapter 4 showed that news media discourses fuel Generalverdacht against refugees and criminalise entire cohorts, leading to the social exclusion of refugees.

The final question posed by this dissertation asked whether the pattern of migration politics in Germany is systematic enough to draw parallels between the reception of separate refugee cohorts, yet flexible enough to account for differences in those receptions. The Constructive Cycle of Migrant Legitimacy (see Figure 3) argues that, while occurring via discursively different themes, refugees are generally excluded in Germany. It explains the disadvantages and anti-migrant discourses faced by both Syrian and Ukrainian refugees, arguing that the cycle of (il)legitimacy that affected Syrian refugees in the 2010s is the same one that affected Ukrainian refugees in the 2020s, and that the construction of their illegitimacy occurred along slightly altered, but nevertheless anti-migrant, discursive lines. The arguments made by this dissertation are perhaps best summed by my interview with Steven Vertovec, who said:

> 'Belonging is not just about identity or emotion. It's regulated. You see it in laws, in discourses, in how states manage people's visibility or invisibility' (Interview with Vertovec, 2025).

The consequences of the processes identified by this work have already begun to occur. In the February 2025 German parliamentary elections, for instance, the right-wing extremist, anti-migrant AfD became the second-largest fraction (*i.e.,* political party) in the Bundestag, outperforming every party offering a pro-migrant platform (*e.g.*, The Greens) and only being beaten out by another party running on an anti-migrant platform, the CDU/CSU (The Federal

Returning Officer, 2025). Furthermore, the now-governing CDU/CSU/SPD coalition in Germany has used securitisation discourse to directly justify their reintroduction of border controls along all its borders, a decision that has been sharply criticised by Germany's neighbours (Directorate-General of Migration and Home Affairs, 2025).

In sum, this dissertation argues that an intersectional framework that incorporates religious identity, race, gender, class and aesthetics best explains refugee exclusion in contemporary Germany. As illustrated by the cases of Syrian and Ukrainian refugee cohorts, legal categories and integration regimes are embedded within a broader framework of "deservingness", which itself is deeply inflected by anti-migrant discourses originating in the news media. The emergence of securitisation discourse in the aftermath of a visibilising event produces a system of migration and integration governance in which refugees are actively excluded from the symbolic and material boundaries of "belonging" in Germany. This dissertation thus contributes to migration studies in showing how institutional practice responds to, reproduces and legitimises social discourse. Future research should examine whether the dynamics observed in Germany are replicated in other European states and should investigate how evolving electoral and international conditions might further entrench or disrupt German hierarchies of inclusion. Further research should also interrogate how the causal process from anti-migrant societal calcification to decisions about admission law functions. Ultimately, who is permitted to belong in Germany is a question of perception, rendered visible through the institutions that govern, exclude and de-legitimise refugees.

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Interviews

Bialas, U. (2025) Research interview. At Café Liebling in Berlin, with Author, 15 April (see Table 1).

Hess, S. (2025) Research interview. On Zoom in Cambridge, with Author, 4 April (see Table 1).

“Interlocutor B”. (2025) Research interview. On Zoom in Cambridge, with Author, 10 April (see Table 1).

“Interlocutor K”. (2025) Research interview. On Zoom in Cambridge, with Author, 28 April (see Table 1).

Mendonça, T. (2025) Research interview. At ChocoLab in Munich, with Author, 11 April (see Table 1).

Romano, C. (2025) Research interview. On Zoom in Cambridge, with Author, 24 April (see Table 1).

Schneider, J. (2025) Research interview. At SVR in Berlin, with Author, 17 April (see Table 1).

Schönwälder, K. (2025) Research interview. At Cerebra Coffee in Berlin, with Author, 16 April (see Table 1).

Vertovec, S. (2025) Research interview. At Max Planck Institute in Göttingen, with Author, 14 April (see Table 1).

Walter-Franke, M. (2025) Research interview. At SVR in Berlin, with Author, 15 April (see Table 1).

Appendix 1: Further Data from News Media Discourse Analysis

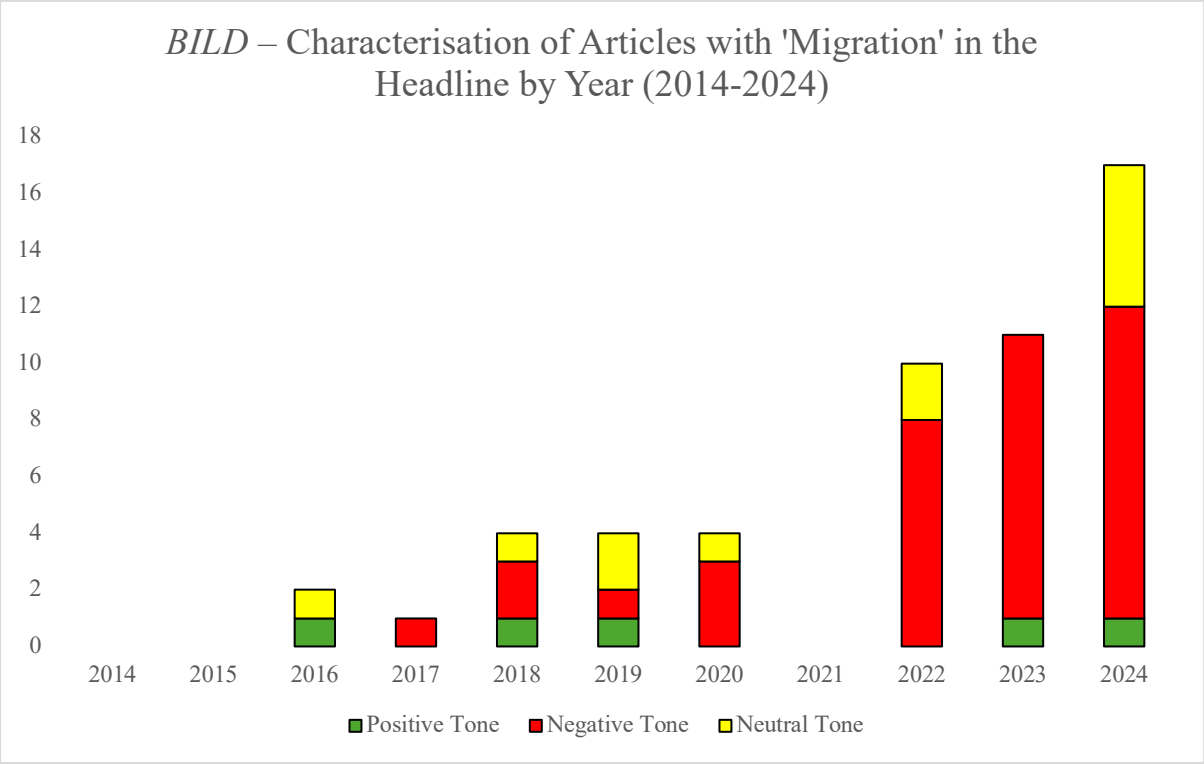

Figure A1: Characterisations of each article examined in BILD *with 'Migration' in the headline, sorted by year (2014-2024).*

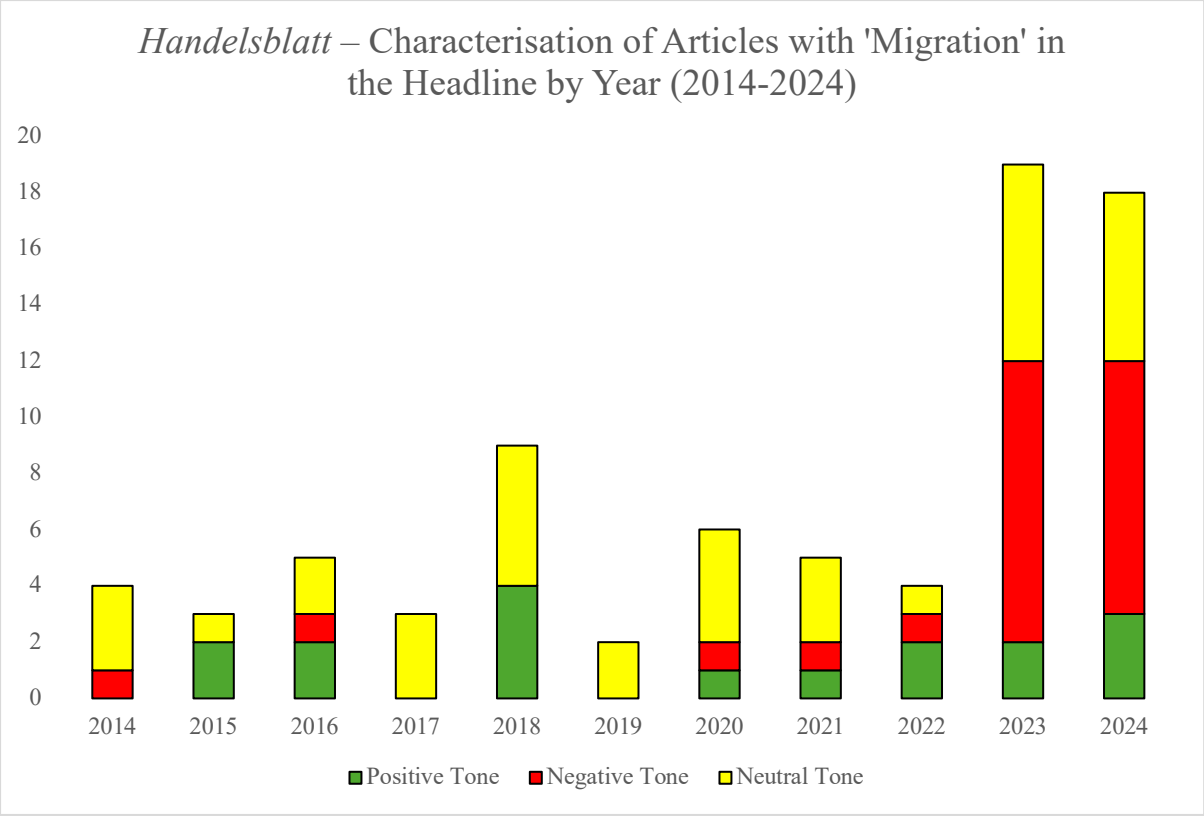

Figure A2: Characterisations of each article examined in Handelsblatt *with 'Migration' in the headline, sorted by year (2014-2024).*

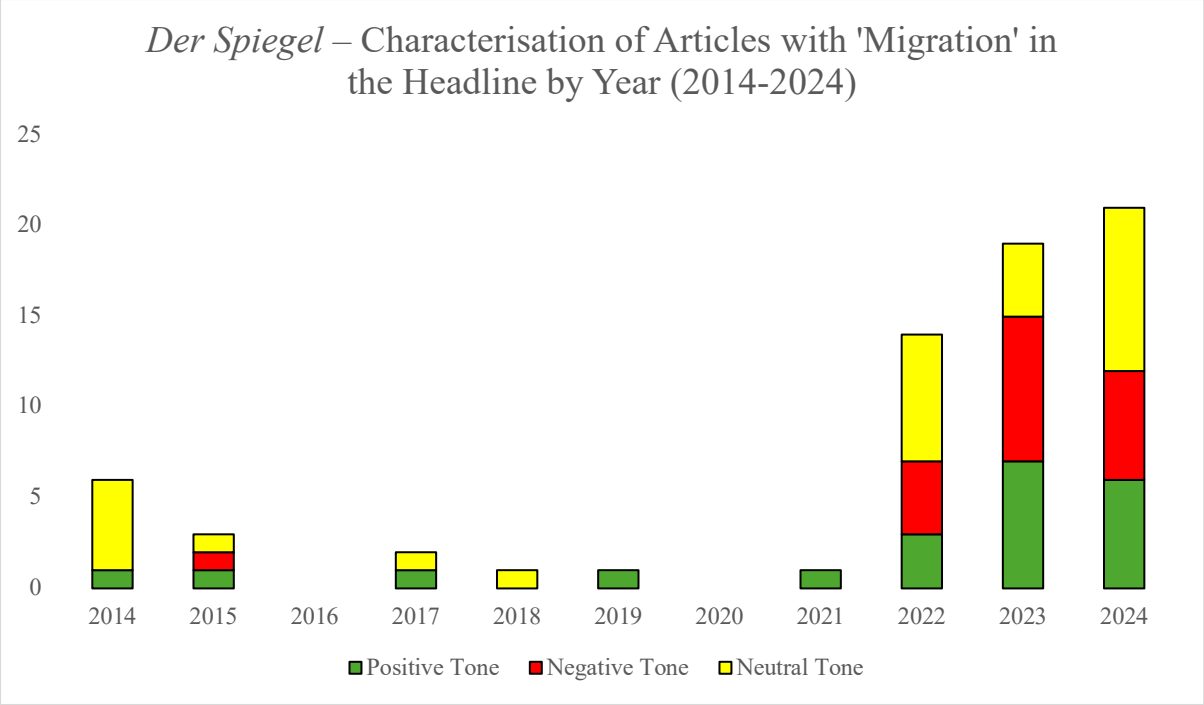

Figure A3: Characterisations of each article examined in Der Spiegel *with 'Migration' in the headline, sorted by year (2014-2024).*

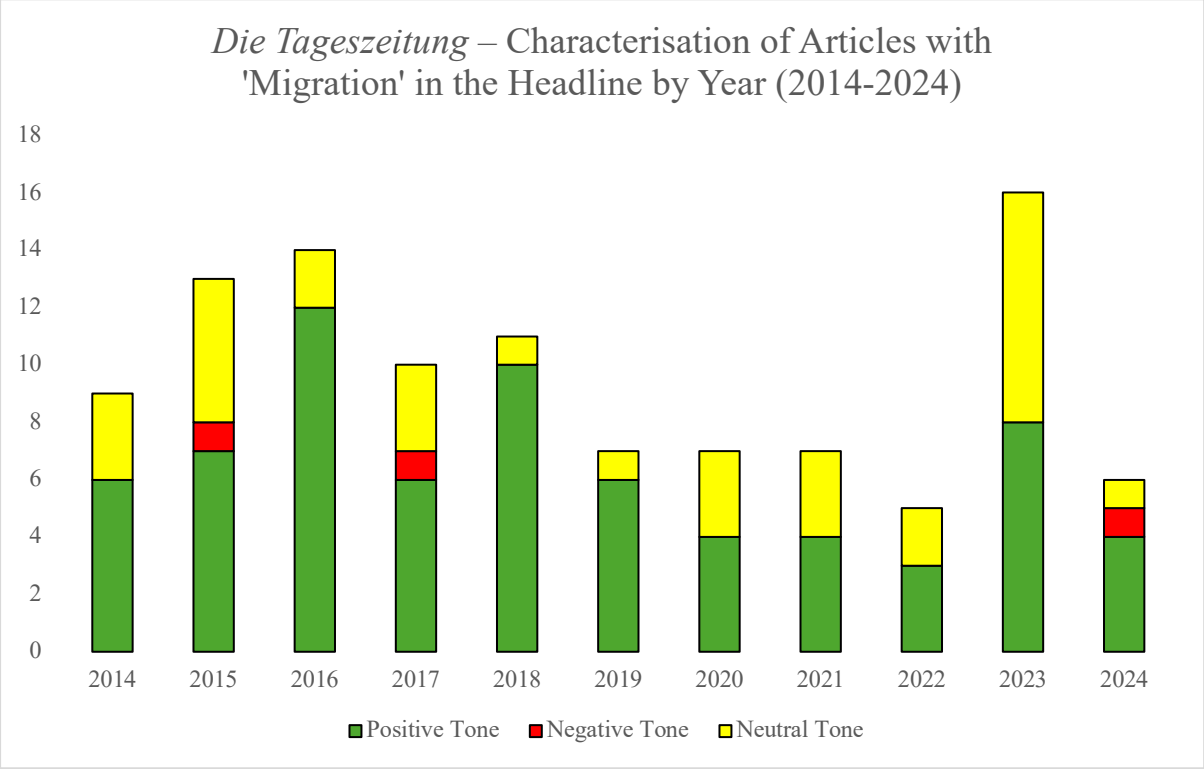

Figure A4: Characterisations of each article examined in Die Tageszeitung *with 'Migration' in the headline, sorted by year (2014-2024).*

Outlet	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
BILD			50	0	25	25	0		0	9.10	5.89
Handelsblatt	0	66.67	40	0	44.44	0	16.67	25	50	10.53	16.67
Der Spiegel	16.67	33.33		50	0	100		100	21.43	36.84	28.57
TAZ	66.67	53.85	85.71	66.67	90.91	85.71	57.14	57.14	60	50	60

Table A1: Heatmap displaying the percentage of articles from each outlet that were positive in tone, sorted by year (2014-2024).

Appendix 2: Full Results from Quantitative Analyses

Hypothesis	Intercept	Estimate (Syrian)	Estimate (Ukrainian)	Estimate (German)	p-value	R^2 (adjusted)	Conclusion
German speaking skills	1.57713	0.98983			0.185	0.0007586	No significance
German writing skills	1.72074	1.7424			0.6636	-0.0008114	No significance
German reading skills	1.675532	1.672			0.9415	-0.0009956	No significance
Grade in German class	2.7273	2.9222			0.5423	-0.0063	No significance
	2.9222		2.7273		0.5423	-0.0063	No significance
German speaking ability	1.3636	1.5			0.4869	-0.005156	No significance
	1.5		1.36364		0.4869	-0.005156	No significance
German writing ability	1.3636	1.6333			0.2156	0.005501	No significance
	1.63333		1.36363		0.2156	0.005501	No significance
Religiosity	5.0087	6.04706	4.75269	2.76471	0.000279	0.005003	Weak or incomplete statistical relationship

Table A2: Table displaying the results of the ordinary least squares regression models on the predictive effect of one's migrant background (Syrian or Ukrainian) on various indicators (DIW Berlin, 2025; Norwegian Agency for Shared Services in Education and Research, 2025).

	German speaking skills	German writing skills	German reading skills	Grade in German class	German speaking ability	German writing ability	Religiosity	Employment status	Unemployment status	Arrest rates	Conviction rates
Syrian	0.185	0.6636	0.9415	0.5423	0.4869	0.2156	0.00237	0.4593	0.1027	2.20E-16	2.20E-16
Ukrainian				0.5423	0.4869	0.2156	0.43347	0.03583	0.004454		
Native German							0.00297				

Table A3: Heatmap displaying the p-values from each quantitative test conducted, with more significant p-values denoted by darker shades of green.